A Living Dataset of International Influence

Raymond Hicks*

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Abstract

How can researchers measure the changing networks through which international influence operates? This paper introduces a living dataset of reported contacts between foreign officials and U.S. government personnel from 1999 to 2023. The underlying records come from annual Foreign Gifts and Decorations Act reports, but the paper treats individual gifts as observable traces of broader relationships: meetings, protocol exchanges, institutional connections, and repeated contact between bureaucracies. The central contribution is an infrastructure for studying these relationships over time. Each foreign and U.S. official is linked to a persistent Wikidata identifier, allowing the dataset to distinguish individuals from offices, follow officials across careers, connect them to external sources, and refresh information as those sources change. The resulting data contain 10,428 reported contacts involving 1,026 U.S. recipients, 2,361 foreign officials, 169 countries, and 107 U.S. agency units. We use the data to construct longitudinal person-level and institutional networks and to examine how bureaucratic roles, professional backgrounds, education, military service, and career mobility structure international contact. Drawing on the revolving-door literature, we argue that influence travels not only through formal institutions but also through the movement and connection of personnel across offices, agencies, and national systems. The dataset provides a platform for studying how those networks form, persist, and change.

Keywords: foreign gifts, bureaucrats, homophily, diplomacy, living data, Wikidata, record linkage, political elites

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1 INTRODUCTION

A Living Dataset of International Influence

Who carries influence across bureaucratic networks: the person, the career, or the office? Research on international politics increasingly shows that individual bureaucrats matter. International staff, diplomats, experts, and policy entrepreneurs shape agenda-setting, implementation, knowledge production, and institutional change (**????**). Yet the growing emphasis on individual agency leaves open a basic question: does influence follow individuals as they move across institutions, or does it attach primarily to the formal positions they occupy?

*Corresponding author: arpie71@gmail.com. Working paper; comments welcome. Code and data: the `gifts` repository. [Co-author names and affiliations to be added.]

Recent work conceptualizes individuals as structurally embedded actors. Their decisions reflect overlapping pressures associated with formal authority, organizational culture, professional networks, national affiliations, and career incentives (**?**). This framework challenges accounts that treat bureaucratic influence as either a simple consequence of organizational position or an attribute of individual expertise. It also directs attention to a central empirical problem: people who occupy similar offices may face different pressures, while the same person may behave differently after moving across institutions.

This article examines that problem through a longitudinal dataset of bureaucratic interactions. We use diplomatic gifts not as an object of substantive interest in themselves, but as systematic records of encounters among individuals, agencies, governments, and organizations. By linking these records to individual identifiers, organizational affiliations, offices, and career histories, we ask whether interaction networks travel with people or remain attached to the organizations and positions they occupy.

The analysis advances three claims. First, position dominates career. Interaction counts are strongly associated with formal office, especially cabinet-level status, but not with career length, prior mobility, or accumulated professional history. This pattern holds both across individuals and within individuals as they move between positions. The finding qualifies the view that accumulated experience or extensive career networks necessarily generate greater influence. In this setting, bureaucratic influence appears to derive primarily from the authority, visibility, and access attached to the current office.

Second, organizations retain foreign relationships when the personnel who carried them leave. When all observed personnel associated with an agency-country relationship depart, the relationship itself becomes less likely to recur. Yet its recurrence through other personnel does not decline appreciably. The departing individual's own contact is lost, but the organization's broader relationship persists through successors. This suggests that institutional continuity depends less on the permanent presence of particular individuals than on organizational routines, records, expectations, and positional access.

Third, brokerage is concentrated and positional. Individuals who connect otherwise separate agencies, countries, or professional communities are overwhelmingly senior officials. Apparent links between career mobility and brokerage largely disappear when compared with degree-preserving null networks, indicating that mobility may appear to generate brokerage because mobile or prominent individuals simply have more ties. Below the cabinet level, brokerage is concentrated among military service chiefs, protocol officers, defense officials, and senior legislators serving on foreign-affairs and armed-services committees. These are not random career generalists; they occupy offices that structurally connect domestic authority to international interaction.

Together, these findings qualify both leader-centered and career-centered accounts of bureaucratic influence. The relevant contrast is not between individuals and institutions, but between person-carried and position-carried influence. Individuals can matter, particularly when they connect organizations or retain relationships after moving. However, the empirical pattern suggests that most observed interaction is generated by formal office and organizational location. The organization does not simply aggregate the preferences and networks of its personnel; it provides the institutional

platform that makes particular forms of access possible.

This paper develops a new data infrastructure for studying those questions. We transform annual reports published under the Foreign Gifts and Decorations Act into a longitudinal record of international contact involving U.S. officials and foreign representatives. The reports identify individuals, offices, agencies, countries, dates, and circumstances associated with reported exchanges. We do not treat any particular exchange as a direct measure of influence. Instead, we use each observation as an observable trace of contact that can be linked to information about the people and institutions involved. Aggregated over time, these traces reveal networks of interaction across agencies, bureaucracies, countries, and professional communities.

The project's theoretical motivation comes from research on bureaucratic careers, elite networks, and revolving doors. Existing work often examines movement between public and private employment or the consequences of post-government careers (Carnes and Lupu, 2023; Lewis, 2008; Teodoro, 2011). Our data extend this perspective to connections among public officials across national and organizational boundaries. They capture interactions among diplomats, military officers, intelligence personnel, legislators, civil servants, and other technical officials. Because the records span twenty-five years, they also allow us to study networks as processes rather than fixed structures. We can ask whether contact follows the office, the person, the career, the institution, or an earlier relationship—and how those patterns change as agencies, administrations, and international conditions change.

To this end, we build a living dataset rather than a static historical file. This approach rebuilding from primary sources whenever new material appears; stores human judgments in versioned lookup files; links people and organizations to persistent identifiers; and preserves the code, source files, and decisions needed to reproduce each release. This setup holds particular benefits for individual-level research. The same official may appear under different names, titles, spellings, transliterations, and offices. A person may serve as a legislator, ambassador, cabinet official, agency head, or military commander over the course of a career. Without a persistent identifier, researchers cannot reliably distinguish office from officeholder or determine whether apparently separate observations concern the same individual.

We use Wikidata identifiers to address this problem (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014). Each linked person receives a Wikidata identifier, or QID, which allows the dataset to connect contact records to information on positions held, dates of service, education, occupation, military experience, employers, party membership, and family relationships. The identifier also makes the dataset extensible: researchers can join it to other person-level datasets, including the Comparative Legislators Database (CLD; Göbel and Munzert, 2022), update contextual information as Wikidata changes, and follow individuals as they move across organizations. The paper therefore contributes not simply a new collection of observations, but a reusable framework for building longitudinal networks of political and bureaucratic contact.

The data support a substantive shift in emphasis. Rather than asking primarily who gave the most valuable gifts, we ask which agencies and bureaucracies interact with which foreign counterparts, which connections persist over time, and whether contact reflects institutional matching or person-level affinity. Do military agencies interact disproportionately with foreign military establishments

because of formal counterpart relationships? Do diplomats maintain cross-national networks after moving between postings? Do officials with shared education, professional training, or career experience appear in the same contact networks? Do changes in administration, conflict, or organizational structure alter these patterns? These questions concern influence, access, and institutional connectivity—not the intrinsic meaning of any particular object exchanged.

The empirical analysis proceeds at three levels. First, we describe the temporal structure of reported contact across U.S. agencies, branches, countries, and foreign institutions. Second, we use persistent identifiers to construct person-level networks and follow officials across offices and careers. Third, we compare the professional, educational, and institutional characteristics of connected officials, using random-pairing baselines to distinguish ordinary institutional matching from person-level similarity. We draw on research showing that social ties form disproportionately among similar people (McPherson et al., 2001), that personal rapport can shape diplomacy (Holmes, 2013), and that universities and military colleges connect national elites across borders (Atkinson, 2010; Ruby and Gibler, 2010; Gift and Krcmaric, 2017).

The analysis is descriptive and exploratory. The data identify patterns of contact and possible relational infrastructure, but they do not by themselves establish that any exchange caused a policy decision or generated influence. Nor can the reports capture every meeting, relationship, or channel of communication. Reporting practices differ across agencies, some records withhold the identity of foreign officials, and the existence of an observed exchange does not reveal what either party intended. These limitations make the dataset an imperfect but valuable starting point for studying the observable institutional traces of international networks.

Our current release contains 10,428 reported contacts involving 1,026 linked U.S. recipients, 2,361 linked foreign officials, 169 countries, and 107 agency units. We show that most observed similarity between foreign officials and U.S. recipients reflects institutional matching: military personnel interact with military organizations, diplomats with diplomatic agencies, and officials in particular branches encounter characteristic foreign counterparts. At the same time, person-level similarities in professional background, birth cohort, and education appear above branch- and year-specific baselines. These patterns suggest that formal offices organize international contact, while individual careers and networks shape how those connections persist and change.

The broader aim is to make international influence more observable. By combining living-data principles, Wikidata-based entity resolution, longitudinal network analysis, and theories of bureaucratic mobility and revolving doors, the project offers a way to study how people—not only states or institutions—carry relationships across organizational and national boundaries.

2 THEORY: CAREERS, STRUCTURAL EMBEDDING, AND BUREAUCRATIC INFLUENCE

Theory: Position, Career, and Organizational Continuity

The contemporary literature on bureaucratic influence emphasizes that international outcomes are shaped by actors embedded within formal organizations and overlapping professional structures. Clark, Dolan, and Jost identify bureaucratic selection and decision-making centralization as key conditions governing influence (**?**). Weaver, Morrison, and Heinzel similarly argue that individuals face

different combinations of structural pressures depending on their affiliations, identities, institutional settings, and professional histories (**?**). Heinzel, Weaver, and Jorgensen show how the composition and representation of international bureaucracies can affect organizational priorities, illustrating that staff characteristics matter through their interaction with institutional roles and organizational processes (**?**).

These arguments generate two competing expectations. A career-centered account predicts that influence accumulates through experience, mobility, and repeated interaction. Individuals who have worked in many organizations should possess more extensive networks, greater institutional knowledge, and more opportunities to broker across organizational boundaries. Their prior relationships should follow them as they move, allowing them to carry connections from one agency to another.

A position-centered account predicts that influence attaches primarily to formal office. Cabinet officials, agency heads, military chiefs, protocol officers, and senior legislators receive more interaction because their offices confer authority, visibility, access, and symbolic importance. From this perspective, personnel movement should matter less than the institutional position a person occupies at a given moment. The same individual should receive more interaction when holding a prominent office and less when holding a less visible position, even if the person's accumulated career history remains constant.

The distinction is consequential because the two accounts imply different mechanisms of institutional influence. If career dominates, organizations are partly containers for person-specific networks. When an official moves, relationships, expertise, and influence should move with them. If position dominates, organizations are more than containers: they structure access independently of the individual who occupies the role. Personnel may change while the organization's external relationships persist because successors inherit the office, the organizational mandate, and the routines through which contact occurs.

The first hypothesis is therefore:

H1: Interaction volume is more strongly associated with formal position than with career length, prior mobility, or accumulated professional history.

This hypothesis has both between-person and within-person implications. Between people, cabinet-level officials should receive more interactions than legislators, agency staff, military personnel, or diplomats, even after accounting for career length and prior appearances. Within people, an individual's interaction rate should change when the person enters or leaves a prominent office. Evidence of both patterns would suggest that formal position, rather than stable individual characteristics, drives the observed interaction volume.

The second hypothesis concerns institutional continuity:

H2: When personnel associated with an agency-country relationship leave, the relationship will continue through other personnel at approximately the same rate.

This hypothesis does not imply that individuals are irrelevant. A departing person's own contacts may disappear, and some relationships may be partially person-carried. But if organizations retain foreign relationships through routines, records, successor access, and institutional expectations, then other personnel should continue the relationship after the original carrier departs. The relevant comparison is therefore not whether the relationship recurs at all, but whether it recurs through the

same individual or through the organization's other personnel.

This distinction follows from the broader literature's emphasis on organizational processes. International bureaucracies develop cultures, routines, and forms of expertise that can outlast individual staff members (**???**). Heinzel and colleagues likewise show that bureaucratic characteristics matter through organizational processes rather than through individual attributes alone (**??**). If institutional relationships are embedded in organizational practice, turnover should not necessarily dissolve them.

The third hypothesis concerns brokerage:

H3: Brokerage is concentrated among individuals occupying positions that structurally connect organizations, countries, or domestic and international authority.

A career-centered account predicts that mobility itself produces brokerage. Officials who have moved across agencies and sectors should connect otherwise separate communities. A positional account predicts that apparent mobility effects will largely disappear once the number of ties is held constant and observed networks are compared with appropriate null graphs. Brokerage should instead be concentrated among offices that routinely connect institutional domains: cabinet positions, military commands, protocol offices, foreign-affairs committees, and senior diplomatic posts.

This expectation also follows from the embedded-agent framework. Individuals do not encounter structural pressures independently of their offices. Their professional histories may shape how they interpret those pressures, but formal roles determine which interactions are available in the first place (**?**). A military service chief or protocol officer may become a broker not because of unusually extensive prior mobility, but because the office itself sits at the intersection of domestic authority, diplomacy, and foreign representation.

The theory therefore distinguishes three mechanisms:

Person-carried influence: relationships, expertise, or access that follow an individual across institutional transitions.

Position-carried influence: interactions generated by the authority, visibility, and institutional access attached to a formal office.

Organization-carried influence: relationships that persist because agencies retain routines, records, mandates, and successor personnel capable of maintaining them.

These mechanisms are not mutually exclusive. The empirical question is their relative importance. A modest person-carried component may coexist with strong organizational continuity. Likewise, a mobile individual may become a broker, but only because the new position provides the authority and access necessary to activate prior relationships.

This framework also clarifies what static datasets cannot observe. A cross-sectional dataset can show that cabinet officials receive more interactions than agency staff, but it cannot establish whether this difference reflects individual reputation, career history, or the formal office. A dataset organized only around organizations can show that an agency maintains foreign relationships, but it cannot reveal whether those relationships persist through the same people or through successors. A static network can identify central actors, but it cannot determine whether brokerage reflects genuine mobility, accumulated ties, or simply degree and prominence.

The longitudinal data allow these mechanisms to be separated. Person-level comparisons identify differences across career types. Within-person transitions show whether interaction changes when the same individual enters a different office. Organization-level turnover tests whether foreign ties persist after personnel change. Tie-level analyses distinguish recurrence through the original carrier from recurrence through other personnel. Finally, degree-preserving permutation tests assess whether the association between career mobility and brokerage exceeds what would be expected from the number of connections alone.

The resulting argument is deliberately narrower than a general claim that bureaucrats do not matter. Individuals matter, but their influence is structured by formal position and organizational context. Career history and mobility may create a modest person-carried component, particularly for selected relationships and brokerage positions. Yet the dominant empirical pattern is that interaction follows the office, while organizations preserve their external ties through personnel change. This suggests that bureaucratic influence is neither wholly individual nor wholly institutional: it is positional in its concentration, organizational in its continuity, and only selectively personal in its transmission.

3 WHAT IS A LIVING DATASET?

LIVING DATASET

A **living dataset** is a continuously updating collection of data that evolves over time rather than remaining frozen in a static state. Concretely, (*a*) it is rebuilt from primary sources by code whenever those sources change; (*b*) human judgments (for example, "this *Abdullah* is `Q57464`") are stored as data in versioned lookup tables, so they persist across rebuilds instead of being redone; (*c*) entities are keyed by persistent identifiers maintained outside the project, so linked attributes can be refreshed; and (*d*) each release is reproducible, so a result can be traced to a specific version of sources, lookups, and code.

Most datasets in political science are *static*: a team codes a population over a fixed window, deposits a file, and moves on. Static datasets are valuable and often superb, but they carry two familiar costs.

Static data are hard to merge. A dataset built around names, or around project-specific numeric codes, can be joined to another only through a crosswalk that someone must build. For countries this problem is largely solved by shared code systems and the tools that translate among them (Arel-Bundock et al., 2018). For individuals it is not. Names are transliterated in many ways (the lookup file maps eleven distinct name strings, among them *Abdelazia*, *Abdelkaziz*, and *Bonteflika*, to Abdelaziz Bouteflika's single QID), titles are folded into names, and the same person appears under different offices. Researchers therefore fall back on fuzzy or probabilistic record linkage (Enamorado et al., 2019). That is feasible but costly, and every research team repeats it with slightly different results.

Static data are hard to update. When a source adds a year, a static dataset either goes out of date or must be reconstructed, often by different people with different rules. The cleaning decisions embedded in the original release (which rows were dropped, how ambiguous names were resolved)

are frequently lost. The transparency and replication literature has long noted this problem (King, 1995; Lupia and Elman, 2014). Event datasets such as GDELT (Leetaru and Schrodt, 2013) show the opposite pole: fully automated and continuously updated, but with limited human verification of who the actors are.

A living dataset sits between these poles. Updating is routine because the pipeline, not a person, does the repetitive work. Human verification is cumulative because it is stored in lookup files the pipeline consults on every run. Merging is cheap because entities are keyed to an external, community-maintained identifier. These features map closely onto the FAIR principles of findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reusability (Wilkinson et al., 2016). The persistent identifier is what makes the data interoperable.

The gift reports suit this model particularly well. They arrive on a predictable annual cycle, roughly a year after the calendar year they cover: the report for calendar year 2024 appeared on January 29, 2026 (Office of the Chief of Protocol, 2026). Their format drifts from year to year, but not by much. And most of their actors are exactly the kind of internationally prominent people Wikidata describes well.

4 THE SOURCE: FOREIGN GIFT REPORTS

The U.S. Constitution's foreign emoluments clause bars federal officers from accepting any "present" from a foreign state without the consent of Congress. The Foreign Gifts and Decorations Act of 1966, codified at 5 U.S.C. § 7342, supplies that consent in a structured form. Employees may accept gifts of "minimal value" (a threshold the General Services Administration revises every three years to track the consumer price index: $390 for 2017–2019, $415 for 2020–2022, and $480 for 2023–2025; General Services Administration 2023). Gifts above the threshold may be accepted when refusing would "cause offense or embarrassment or otherwise adversely affect the foreign relations of the United States," but they become property of the United States and must be reported. Each employing agency compiles these reports, and the State Department publishes the combined list annually. The statute's definition of "foreign government" includes international organizations, so the World Health Organization and NATO bodies appear as givers alongside heads of state. Agencies may also withhold the giver's identity when publishing it would harm intelligence sources (§ 7342(f)(4)). We return to this below.

The project does not treat gifts as intrinsically important objects or seek to explain gift-giving as an isolated diplomatic practice. Instead, gifts provide unusually systematic records of interactions among individuals, agencies, governments, and international organizations, often identifying participants, institutional affiliations, dates, locations, and the context of an encounter. The substantive object of interest is therefore not the gift itself but the interaction it records: repeated exchanges can reveal who meets whom, which agencies interact, how relationships persist across changes in office, and whether particular individuals connect otherwise separate institutional communities. By linking these records to individual identifiers, career histories, organizational affiliations, and subsequent meetings, the project uses gift data to study the formation, maintenance, and transformation of bureaucratic networks over time.

Each published entry has four fields:

- **Recipient**: name, title, and often the organization ("Admiral John Richardson, U.S. Navy, Chief of Naval Operations");
- **Gift**: a free-text block that packs together the description of the item, the date received, the estimated value, and the disposition ("... Rec'd—August 28, 2002. Est. Value—$1,000,000. Archives Foreign");
- **Giver**: honorific, name, title, and country ("His Royal Highness Prince Bandar bin Sultan, Ambassador of Saudi Arabia");
- **Circumstances**: the justification for acceptance (most often the non-embarrassment clause).

Entries are grouped into agency sections, such as "The White House—Executive Office of the President," "Department of the Navy," and "United States Senate," and the grouping is itself informative. The reports are published as structured XML, which we use, though the content of each cell is free text.

Most of the people in these records are not elected. Ambassadors, assistant secretaries, admirals, generals, and agency heads together receive more gifts than presidents and members of Congress, and each gift names both the American official and the foreign official who presented it. The records therefore let us ask two questions about the bureaucracy that are hard to answer elsewhere. First, *who* are the American officials that foreign governments cultivate, and how do they differ across the diplomatic, defense, intelligence, and domestic agencies? Second, *what do givers and recipients share*? Social ties form disproportionately among similar people (McPherson et al., 2001), personal rapport is a resource in diplomacy (Holmes, 2013), and American universities and military colleges have trained a large share of the world's elites (Atkinson, 2010; Ruby and Gibler, 2010; Gift and Krcmaric, 2017). If foreign governments direct gifts toward officials who resemble their own representatives, by career, generation, or schooling, then the gift record captures relationships that run between people and not only between offices. Answering either question requires knowing much more about givers and recipients than the gift reports contain.

5 THE PIPELINE

Table 1 summarizes the pipeline. Each stage reads the output of the previous one, so a new annual report can be added with one download command and one rebuild.

5.1 ACQUISITION AND PARSING

The reports are published in the *Federal Register* without a dedicated landing page, so each year's XML URL is recorded once in `files/urls.csv`. The download step stores both the original XML and a raw CSV, so later stages can return to the source. Parsing is mostly regular-expression work, but three features of the source deserve mention because they recur in other government registers.

First, multi-item listings name the recipient and giver once and leave later rows blank; forward-filling restores the pair for each item. *Second*, the gift field packs several variables into one string, and the labels drift across years ("Est. Value—," "Estimated Value:," "Appraised Value"). The parser peels labeled fields off the end of the string. Where a disposition appears without a label ("$280. Government Property"), the parser does not try to enumerate the open-ended set of disposition

Table 1. Pipeline stages, scripts, and outputs.

Stage	Script	What it does
1. Acquire	`download_data.py`	Fetches the Federal Register XML for a report year (URLs kept in `files/urls.csv`); archives the XML; writes one raw CSV per year.
2. Parse	`parseandclean_new.py`	Forward-fills recipient and giver across multi-item listings; splits the gift blob into item, receipt date, value, disposition, location; splits names from honorifics, ranks, titles, and organizations; standardizes dates.
3. Resolve	`wikifind.py`, `masterwiki_new.csv`, `groups.csv`, `nowiki2.txt`	Searches Wikidata for unmatched names, has a human verify the candidates, and stores the verified mappings as lookup tables that every later run reuses. Resolves bare offices ("President") to the holder in that year.
4. Enrich	`scripts/wiki_properties.py`	Downloads selected Wikidata statements (positions held with start/end dates, citizenship, education, party, occupation, military rank, employer, family, and so on) for every linked QID. The countries of the educational institutions are looked up once and cached.
5. Analyze	`analysis/build_analysis_data.py`	Recovers the reporting agency from the XML section headings and groups agencies into branches; assigns giver country and giver type; builds person-level edge lists and a balanced country-year panel.
6. Describe	`analysis/descriptives.py` (`.do`)	Produces the tables and figures in this paper and an interactive map.

phrases. It instead reads the value expression, whose vocabulary is closed (currency amounts, "each," "approximately," punctuation), and treats whatever follows as the disposition. *Third*, honorifics and ranks ("His Excellency," "The Right Honorable," "Admiral") are split from names before matching, because they otherwise defeat any name lookup.

5.2 ENTITY RESOLUTION TO WIKIDATA

Name resolution is deliberately *semi*-automated. For each name without a QID, a SPARQL query returns Wikidata humans whose label or alias matches. A human then confirms, rejects, or corrects the candidates. Fully automated matching is unsafe: a query for "Qin Gang" returns five people. Confirmed matches are written to a master lookup file (`masterwiki_new.csv`, currently about 4,700 name-to-QID mappings). Names that are confirmed to have no Wikidata item are written to an exclusion list, so they are not searched again. Non-person givers and recipients receive explicit codes: `FAMILY` for joint gifts from a royal couple, `GROUP` for delegations, `UNCLEAR` for unresolvable cases, and `NIL` for statutory placeholders such as "5 U.S.C. 7342(f)(4)." This separates "not yet looked up" from "looked up and not a person," a distinction a living dataset needs.

Recipients recorded only by role ("President," "Vice President," "First Lady") are resolved by year to the person who held the role. This is the first, simplest instance of the office/officeholder distinction we develop in Section C.4.

5.3 RECOVERING THE REPORTING AGENCY

The reporting agency is not a field in the parsed data, but the XML encodes it. From 2001 onward each agency's table carries a title (`<TTITLE>Agency: Department of the Navy</TTITLE>`). In 1999 and 2000 the agency appears as a one-cell row inside a single long table. Walking the XML rows in document order assigns every gift to an agency. All 10,428 records receive one, under 107 distinct labels, which we group into seven branches: White House (including the Office of the Vice President and the National Security Council), Diplomatic (State, USAID), Defense (the department, the services, and combatant commands), Intelligence (CIA, ODNI, DIA), Legislative (House, Senate, GAO), Judicial, and Other executive. The agency tells us *which institution* reported the gift; the recipient's QID tells us *who* received it.

5.4 GIVER COUNTRY AND GIVER TYPE

We assign each gift a giving country from the text of the giver field, which almost always names the government ("... King of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia"). Where the text names no country, we fall back on the giver's Wikidata country of citizenship (P27). Regime-specific Wikidata items ("Islamic Republic of Afghanistan," "Great Socialist People's Libyan Arab Jamahiriya") are folded into the continuing state, so each country keeps a single identifier and ISO 3166 code across the panel. This yields a country for 84% of gifts. Nearly all of the rest are gifts with a withheld giver identity or gifts from international organizations, which we code as their own giver type. As a check, where both sources are available (more than 5,000 gifts), the text-based country and the Wikidata citizenship agree 99% of the time. We also classify the giver's role from honorifics and titles: royalty, head of state or government, minister, military officer, diplomat, legislator, intelligence or security official, or international organization.

5.5 THE ANNUAL UPDATE CYCLE

Adding a year requires (*i*) recording the new XML URL, (*ii*) running the download and parse scripts, (*iii*) reviewing only the names that are new to the lookup files, and (*iv*) re-running enrichment and analysis. Step (*iii*) is the only manual one, and its cost falls over time. Heads of state, ministers, and senior American officials recur year after year, so each annual report adds proportionally fewer unmatched names. Table 2 shows the flip side: the newest period, 2019–2023, has the lowest linkage rate because its names have had the least review. In a living dataset, linkage rates are a release-specific quantity that should rise over time. In a static file, they are a permanent property of the data.

6 DESCRIPTIVE OVERVIEW

The current release contains 10,428 gifts reported between 1999 and 2023 (Table 2). It covers 1,026 distinct recipients and 2,361 distinct givers with Wikidata identifiers, and givers from 169 countries. Seventy-one percent of gifts have a resolved recipient and 76% a resolved giver. Ninety-four percent have a parseable dollar value; the median non-travel gift is worth about $580, and the largest single item is a $1,000,000 C. M. Russell painting presented by Saudi Arabia's ambassador to the First

Table 2. Overview by five-year period. "Recip./Giver linked" is the share of gifts whose recipient or giver is resolved to a Wikidata QID. Median value excludes gifts of travel and is in nominal dollars.

Period	Gifts	Recipients (QID)	Givers (QID)	Countries	Recip. linked	Giver linked	Median value ($)
1999–2003	2,303	213	529	123	70%	81%	450
2004–2008	2,285	230	617	138	81%	84%	460
2009–2013	2,688	373	845	137	68%	73%	680
2014–2018	2,139	336	677	137	69%	74%	650
2019–2023	1,013	177	332	104	62%	62%	795
All years	10,428	1,026	2,361	169	71%	76%	580

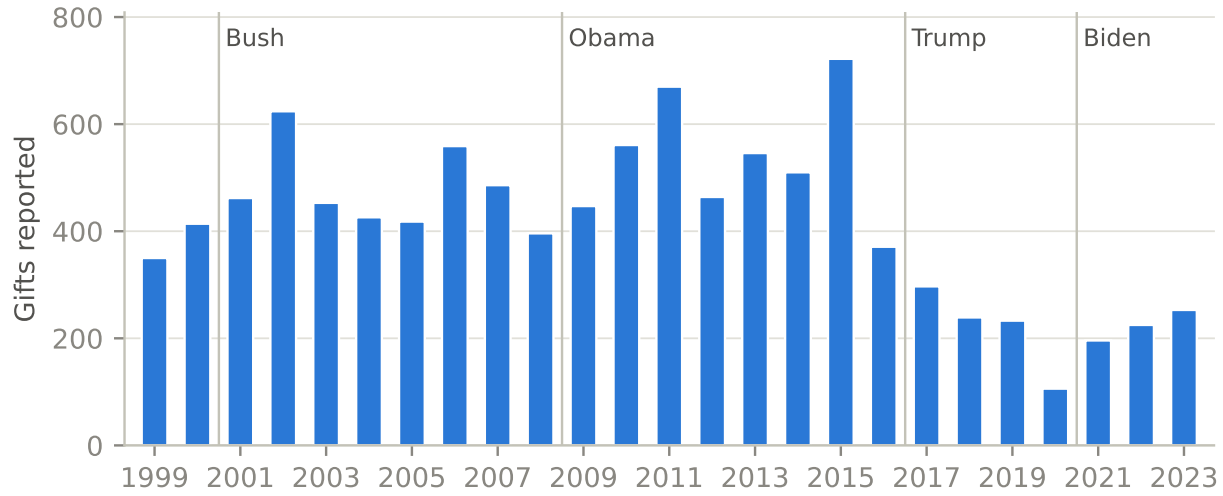


Figure 1. Gifts reported per year (report year), 1999–2023. Vertical rules mark presidential transitions.

Family in 2002. About 11% are gifts of travel or lodging, concentrated in Congress and the smaller executive agencies.

Figure 1 shows the volume of reported gifts over time. Reports rose through the Obama administration, peaking at 722 in 2015, and then fell sharply: 4,291 gifts were reported for 2009–2016 against 1,549 for 2017–2023, with a low of 106 in 2020. The pandemic explains part of the 2020 trough. The 2017–2019 decline, however, began before the pandemic, and whether it reflects fewer gifts, less reporting, or changes in compilation is an open question that the data invite rather than answer. A 2024 Inspector General report found weak controls over foreign gifts (GSA Office of Inspector General, 2024). The figure also contains a measurement lesson: the 2015 spike is partly a backlog. The 2015 Senate report includes 243 gifts received years earlier, by members such as Joe Biden and Hillary Clinton while they were still senators. We therefore keep both the *report year* and the *receipt year* (available from the gift's date for 92% of records). In about 5% of records the two differ by more than a year.

6.1 RECIPIENTS BY BRANCH

The branch of the reporting agency structures almost everything about a gift (Table 3, Figure 2). The White House accounts for 37% of gifts. These are the gifts of summit diplomacy, given

Table 3. Gifts by branch of the reporting agency. "Confidential giver" is the share of gifts where the giver is withheld under 5 U.S.C. § 7342(f)(4). "Travel" is the share that are gifts of travel or lodging.

Branch	Gifts	Share	Agencies	Recip. linked	Giver linked	Confidential giver	Travel
White House	3,827	37%	16	84%	91%	0%	0%
Diplomatic	1,655	16%	9	76%	84%	0%	2%
Defense	1,890	18%	15	69%	69%	0%	3%
Legislative	1,115	11%	7	73%	90%	0%	41%
Intelligence	947	9%	4	35%	1%	99%	2%
Other executive	952	9%	55	46%	75%	0%	57%
Judicial	42	0%	1	83%	81%	0%	71%

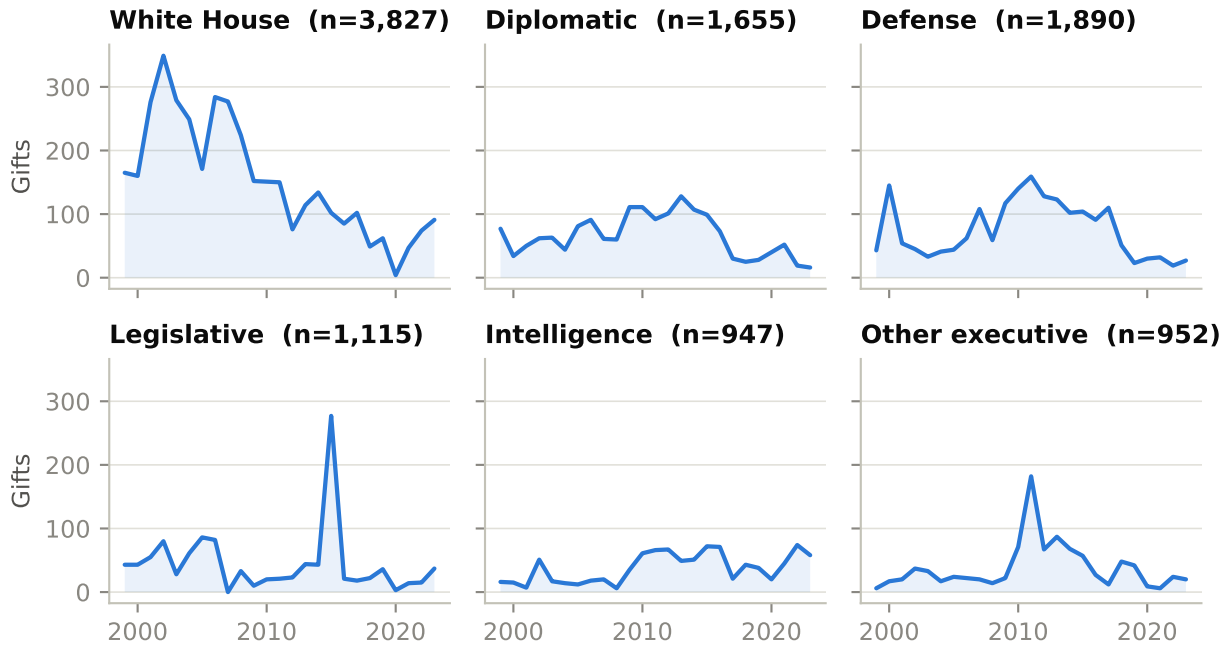


Figure 2. Gifts per year by branch of the reporting agency (report year). Panels share a y-axis. The Judicial branch (42 gifts) is omitted.

overwhelmingly by heads of state and royalty and almost all resolvable to named people. Defense (18%) and Diplomatic (16%) agencies follow. Defense gifts flow largely from foreign military officers to American commanders, and their volume tracks the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan, peaking around 2011. Congress (11%) is distinctive in that 41% of its reported gifts are travel, which reflects congressional delegations. The intelligence community (9%) is almost entirely opaque: 99% of its gifts list the giver only as "5 U.S.C. 7342(f)(4)," and only 35% of its recipients are named. This is a substantive feature, not a parsing failure, and analysts should treat intelligence gifts as an *institution-level* rather than a person-level record.

6.2 GIVERS AND RECIPIENTS BY LEVEL

Figure 3 cross-tabulates the level of the giver against the branch of the recipient. The diagonal structure is striking: foreign governments match the rank and function of their counterpart. Heads

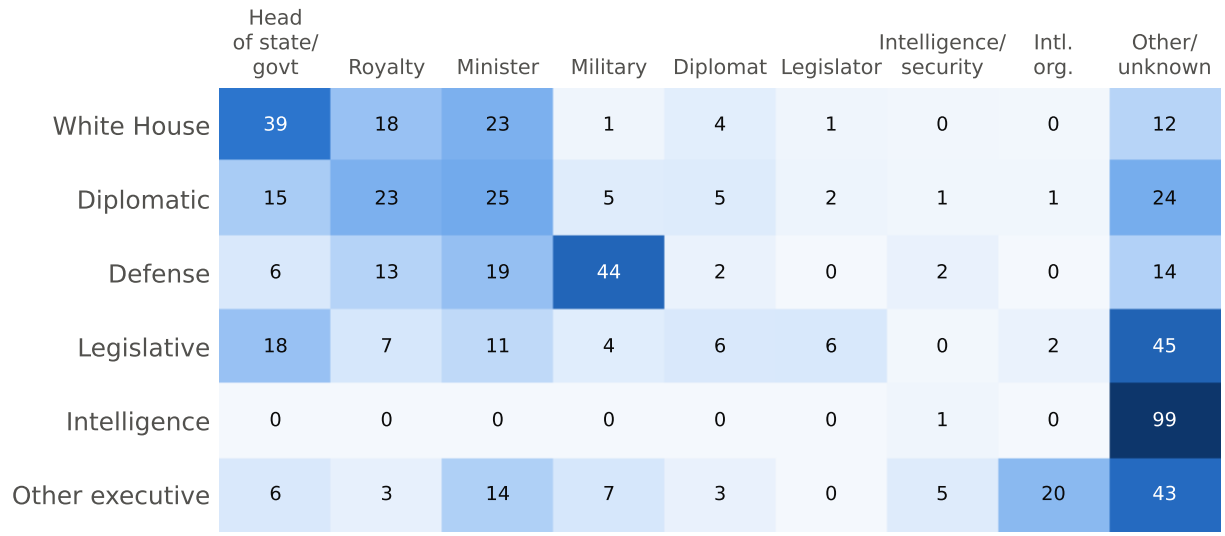


Figure 3. Who gives to whom. Cells show the percentage of each recipient branch's gifts that come from each type of giver (rows sum to 100). Giver type is coded from honorifics and titles.

of state and government account for 40% of gifts to the White House, and royalty for another 18%. Military officers account for 44% of gifts to Defense. Ministers are spread across the White House, State, and Defense, consistent with their role as counterparts to cabinet secretaries. Foreign legislators are a small share of givers even to Congress. Most gifts to Congress come from heads of government, ministers, and unspecified officials, many of them hosting congressional delegations abroad. The pattern suggests that the gift record captures *protocol-matched* contact: each tier of the U.S. government has a characteristic foreign counterpart. This is the kind of relationship that a network view of the data (Section 10) makes visible.

6.3 INDIVIDUALS

Tables 4 and 5 list the most frequent recipients and givers. Presidents and their spouses dominate the recipient list; George W. Bush alone received 888 reported gifts. Secretaries of State come next. The giver list is a roster of long-serving leaders, above all Gulf and Middle Eastern monarchs: Abdullah II of Jordan (210 gifts, 2000–2023), King Abdullah of Saudi Arabia, Hamid Karzai, and Qatar's Hamad bin Ali Al Attiyah. Long tenure means many opportunities to give. The values are highly skewed. King Abdullah's 188 gifts total $5.9 million, much of it in jewelry sets presented to first ladies, cabinet officials, and their spouses, while Brunei's sultan gave 96 gifts worth about $120,000 in total.

6.4 COUNTRIES

Table 6 and Figure 4 aggregate gifts to the country level. Saudi Arabia (477 gifts, $8.6 million), Qatar, Afghanistan, Jordan, China, and the United Arab Emirates lead. Gulf states are heavily overrepresented relative to their population or economic size, consistent with a gift-giving diplomatic culture and close security ties. The heatmap shows that country-level gift flows carry the imprint

Table 4. Top recipients by number of gifts (Wikidata-linked). Value is the nominal sum of estimated values. Branch lists every branch under which the person received gifts.

Name	Branch	Wikidata	Gifts	Years	Value ($)
George W. Bush	White House	Q207	888	2001–2008	1,107,429
Barack Obama	White House, Legislative	Q76	482	2005–2016	2,031,573
Laura Bush	White House	Q152019	445	2001–2008	470,173
Hillary Clinton	White House, Diplomatic, Legislative	Q6294	298	1999–2015	1,278,972
Condoleezza Rice	White House, Diplomatic	Q47216	246	2001–2008	1,265,892
Joe Biden	White House, Legislative	Q6279	229	2000–2023	554,104
John Kerry	Diplomatic, Legislative	Q22316	165	2001–2023	338,428
Michelle Obama	White House	Q13133	154	2009–2016	1,847,616
Bill Clinton	White House, Diplomatic	Q1124	151	1999–2010	222,532
Colin Powell	Diplomatic	Q150851	150	2001–2016	183,094
Dick Cheney	White House	Q48259	101	2004–2008	210,735
Donald Rumsfeld	Defense	Q184650	88	2001–2006	151,621
John Owen Brennan	White House, Intelligence	Q984191	83	2009–2016	133,782
Donald Trump	White House	Q22686	82	2017–2019	230,192
Robert Gates	Defense	Q212979	79	2006–2011	64,040

Table 5. Top givers by number of gifts (Wikidata-linked).

Name	Country	Wikidata	Gifts	Years	Value ($)
Abdullah II of Jordan	Jordan	Q57464	210	2000–2023	332,229
Abdullah of Saudi Arabia	Saudi Arabia	Q57298	188	2000–2018	5,903,000
Hamid Karzai	Afghanistan	Q43944	160	2002–2020	276,648
Hamad bin Ali Al Attiyah	Qatar	Q21004768	129	2001–2018	380,328
Silvio Berlusconi	Italy	Q11860	124	2001–2015	404,420
Hassanal Bolkiah I of Brunei	Brunei	Q57327	96	1999–2023	118,589
Mohammed VI of Morocco	Morocco	Q57553	69	1999–2016	291,119
Mohamed Hussein Tantawi	Egypt	Q45917	64	1999–2011	40,210
Salman bin Hamad, Crown Prince of Bahrain	Bahrain	Q58140	63	2000–2023	140,156
Ali Bin Fetais Al-Marri	Qatar	Q55081149	61	2006–2019	190,397
Sabah Al-Ahmad Al-Jaber Al-Sabah	Kuwait	Q57555	53	2001–2019	171,860
Pervez Musharraf	Pakistan	Q40495	50	2000–2015	33,572
Abd al-Aziz Boutafliqa	Algeria	Q57308	50	2000–2016	41,882
Islam Karimov	Uzbekistan	Q57558	46	1999–2015	29,754
World Health Organization	(intl. org.)	Q7817	45	2007–2019	103,219

of events: Afghanistan and Iraq rise and fall with U.S. deployments, Qatar's gifts climb through the 2010s as Al Udeid became the hub of U.S. air operations, and Russia's are concentrated in the early 2000s and nearly vanish after 2016. Only Saudi Arabia, Jordan, China, the UAE, Pakistan, Bahrain, and South Korea give in every one of the 25 years.

7 EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS: POSITION, ORGANIZATION, AND BROKERAGE

This section tests the three hypotheses in the theory section. It is descriptive. No design here isolates variation in careers, appointments, or personnel turnover that is unrelated to what an office does, so none of the estimates below are causal effects. Each result is labeled by the comparison it makes:

Table 6. Top giving countries. "Active years" is the number of report years (of 25) with at least one gift. "Main recipient branch" is the modal branch.

Country	ISO3	Gifts	Active years	Recipients	Value ($)	Main recipient branch
Saudi Arabia	SAU	477	25	131	8,554,042	White House
Qatar	QAT	438	24	124	1,343,133	Defense
Afghanistan	AFG	383	22	122	539,854	Defense
Jordan	JOR	337	25	88	430,180	White House
China	CHN	293	25	105	334,720	White House
United Arab Emirates	ARE	278	25	93	583,853	Defense
Pakistan	PAK	254	25	105	213,268	Legislative
Italy	ITA	242	23	70	516,856	White House
Bahrain	BHR	234	25	76	530,229	Diplomatic
Iraq	IRQ	211	19	87	257,971	Defense
Japan	JPN	192	24	68	232,363	White House
Kuwait	KWT	190	23	58	372,511	Defense
Egypt	EGY	184	24	71	159,614	Defense
South Korea	KOR	183	25	71	170,893	White House
Russia	RUS	178	21	52	220,494	White House
India	IND	160	24	59	209,718	White House
Turkey	TUR	153	19	47	103,373	White House
France	FRA	148	22	48	220,340	White House
Brunei	BRN	140	19	32	422,239	White House
Mexico	MEX	136	21	47	103,790	White House

- **B**, between people;
- **W**, within the same person over time;
- **O**, within an organization over time;
- **N**, change in the network as a whole;
- **X**, a cross-sectional association.

Appendix A defines every measure and documents sample construction. Appendix B maps each claim to its evidence. The analysis code is in `analysis_revised/` and is described in its replication log.

7.1 DATA AND MEASURES

Interactions. A gift record is the trace of an encounter between a U.S. official, the agency that reports the gift, a foreign official, and a foreign government. The gift itself is not the outcome of interest. We count interactions; their value is not used.

Recipient-year panel. The person-level analysis covers the 1,015 U.S. recipients linked to a human Wikidata item, in receipt years 1998–2023. Career information comes from dated Wikidata positions (P39) and employers (P108). Each spell is assigned to a sector (legislature, national executive, diplomatic, military, subnational, judiciary, international organization, academic or research, private) and to an organization.

A person is in the risk set in years when they hold a dated U.S. public position or receive a gift, so years with no gifts are meaningful zeros. Career measures are available for 590 recipients, and

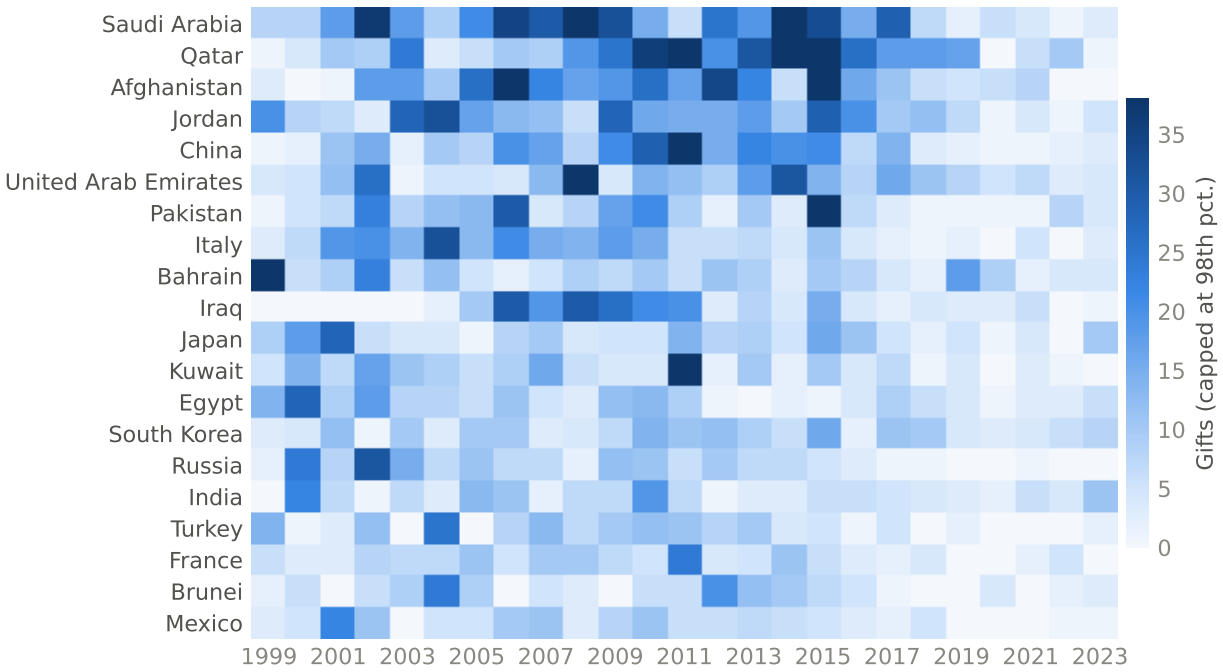


Figure 4. Gifts per year from the twenty most frequent giving countries. Darker cells mean more gifts. The scale is capped at the 98th percentile so a few extreme cells do not wash out the rest.

the coverage is uneven: 93% of cabinet-level officials have a dated career, against 36% of agency, military, and diplomatic staff. The comparisons below are therefore weighted toward visible offices.

Recipients fall into four prominence groups:

- cabinet level and above (170 people);
- family members of presidents and vice presidents (13);
- legislators (264);
- agency, military, and diplomatic staff (568).

Career measures. All career and history measures use only information from before year t.

- *Career length*: years since the first dated spell.
- *Tenure*: years in the current organization, merging consecutive spells there.
- *Prior appearances*: gifts received before t.
- *Prior organizations*: distinct organizations in earlier spells.
- *Mobility*: changes of sector between consecutive spells, and moves between the public, private, academic, and international-organization domains.
- *Cabinet-level office*: whether the person holds a cabinet-level or higher U.S. office in t.

Table 7. Formal position, career, and interaction counts (person-year). Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood; standard errors clustered by person in parentheses. The outcome is the number of gifts received in year t. Columns 1 and 3 compare people (B), with year and current-sector fixed effects. Columns 2 and 4 compare the same person over time (W), with person and year fixed effects. Career length drops out of the within-person models because it is collinear with person and year fixed effects. Columns 3–4 exclude everyone who ever held a cabinet-level office. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

	(1) All	(2) All	(3) No cabinet	(4) No cabinet
Holds cabinet-level office	1.455***	2.197***		
	(0.147)	(0.297)		
log(1 + career length)	0.023		-0.353**	
	(0.093)		(0.127)	
log(1 + tenure in organization)	-0.411***	-0.169*	0.073	0.037
	(0.094)	(0.081)	(0.105)	(0.111)
log(1 + prior appearances)	0.607***	-0.217***	0.603***	-0.738***
	(0.043)	(0.054)	(0.114)	(0.135)
Prior organizations	0.005	0.557***	0.151*	0.600**
	(0.065)	(0.162)	(0.072)	(0.187)
Prior cross-sector moves	0.114	0.135	-0.042	-0.536
	(0.065)	(0.303)	(0.129)	(0.284)
Prior public/private/academic/IO moves	-0.035	-0.034	-0.199	-0.764
	(0.099)	(0.380)	(0.162)	(0.487)
Evidence type	B	W	B	W
Fixed effects	year, sector	person, year	year, sector	person, year
People	548	465	396	323
Person-years	5,610	5,361	4,390	4,171

Network measures. The person-level network is the bipartite graph of linked recipients and giving countries. Built from one year's gifts it is contemporaneous; built from earlier years it is lagged. For each recipient we compute:

- *degree*: the number of countries;
- *betweenness*: normalized shortest-path betweenness;
- *participation*: the participation coefficient of the person's ties across Louvain communities, so 0 means all ties fall in one community;
- *brokerage*: whether the person reaches two or more communities.

For the whole-period broker rankings, a tripartite graph adds the reporting agencies, so a person scores high by connecting agencies and governments that are otherwise far apart.

Turnover and tie recurrence. An agency-country-year tie exists when a country gives to linked recipients of an agency in year t; those recipients are the tie's *carriers*. A carrier has left if they never again receive gifts under that agency. The tie recurs if the country gives to the agency in any of the next three years. Recurrence is split by who receives the later gift: the original carriers, other personnel of the agency, or anyone. At the agency-year level, *turnover* is the share of last year's linked recipients not observed this year.

7.2 POSITION VERSUS CAREER

Table 7 estimates interaction counts from formal position, career length, tenure, prior appearances, and mobility. Four findings stand out.

Formal position is the strongest correlate of interaction. Between people, holding a cabinet-level office is associated with about 4.3 times as many gifts in a year (coefficient 1.46, SE 0.15). The within-person association is larger: the same person receives about nine times as many gifts in years in cabinet-level office as in other years (2.20, SE 0.30).

The event-time estimates in Table 8 and Figure 5 tell the same story (W). Gifts rise sharply in the year a person enters a cabinet-level office (1.79 log points, 26 moves), with no clear rise in gifts beforehand. The number of countries, however, is already higher two to three years before entry (0.57, SE 0.19), so anticipation cannot be ruled out for that outcome. Lateral or non-cabinet moves show no comparable change (0.32, SE 0.51; 78 moves). Among agency, military, and diplomatic staff the post-move coefficient is 1.45 (SE 0.73), but the pre-period coefficient is 0.95 (SE 0.48), so differential trends cannot be ruled out. Assigning the same move years to randomly chosen non-movers 200 times gives a mean post-move coefficient of −0.01 (SD 0.25), against an observed 1.23 for all moves. The pattern is therefore not an artifact of the stacked design. It is a change of office, which is what the positional account predicts.

Career length is not positively associated with interaction. Across all people it is unrelated to interaction counts (0.02, SE 0.09). Among people who never held cabinet office it is *negatively* associated with gifts (−0.35, SE 0.13). Long-serving legislators account for much of that group: they have the longest recorded careers and receive comparatively few gifts per year. Neither result supports the career-centered expectation that accumulated experience brings more interaction.

Tenure is negatively associated with interaction, but the association depends on cabinet officials. Between people, longer tenure in the current organization goes with fewer gifts (−0.41, SE 0.09), and the within-person association is weaker (−0.17, SE 0.08). Without cabinet officials both are near zero (0.07 and 0.04). The coefficient should not be read as interaction declining over a career. Cabinet terms are short and their gift-intensive first years weigh heavily, and long-tenured officeholders such as legislators sit in less gift-intensive offices.

Repeated appearances differ across people but do not accumulate within people. People with more earlier appearances receive more gifts (B: 0.61, SE 0.04). Within the same person the sign reverses (−0.22, and −0.74 without cabinet officials). That reversal reflects mean reversion and the known bias of lagged outcomes in fixed-effects models, not evidence that interaction decays. The defensible conclusion is that repeated appearance marks persistent differences between people, not a within-person stock that grows.

Two further results complete the picture:

- *Mobility.* Prior cross-sector and domain moves are unrelated to interaction counts in every column.
- *Prior organizations.* The within-person coefficient is positive (0.56, and 0.60 without cabinet officials). This count rises only when a person moves, so it captures the same contrast as the event study. Among staff alone it loses significance once the ten most-observed staff are

Table 8. Interactions before and after a change of organization (stacked event study, W). Poisson PML with stack-by-person and stack-by-year fixed effects; standard errors clustered by person. Treated: linked recipients in a dated U.S. public position in $g-1$ who start a spell in a new organization in g, with no other move within three years. Controls: people in office in $g-1$ with no move within three years. "After" pools $t \geq g$; "before" pools $g-3$ and $g-2$; the reference year is $g-1$.

Move	Events	Gifts: after	Gifts: before	Countries: after	Countries: before
Into cabinet-level office	26	1.790***	0.273	1.822***	0.565**
		(0.498)	(0.274)	(0.537)	(0.186)
Lateral or non-cabinet move	78	0.321	0.268	0.318	0.040
		(0.510)	(0.198)	(0.511)	(0.161)
Move by agency, military, or diplomatic staff	26	1.447*	0.948	1.195	0.674
		(0.731)	(0.484)	(0.770)	(0.531)
Any change of organization	104	1.370***	0.203	1.231***	0.234
		(0.209)	(0.187)	(0.182)	(0.159)

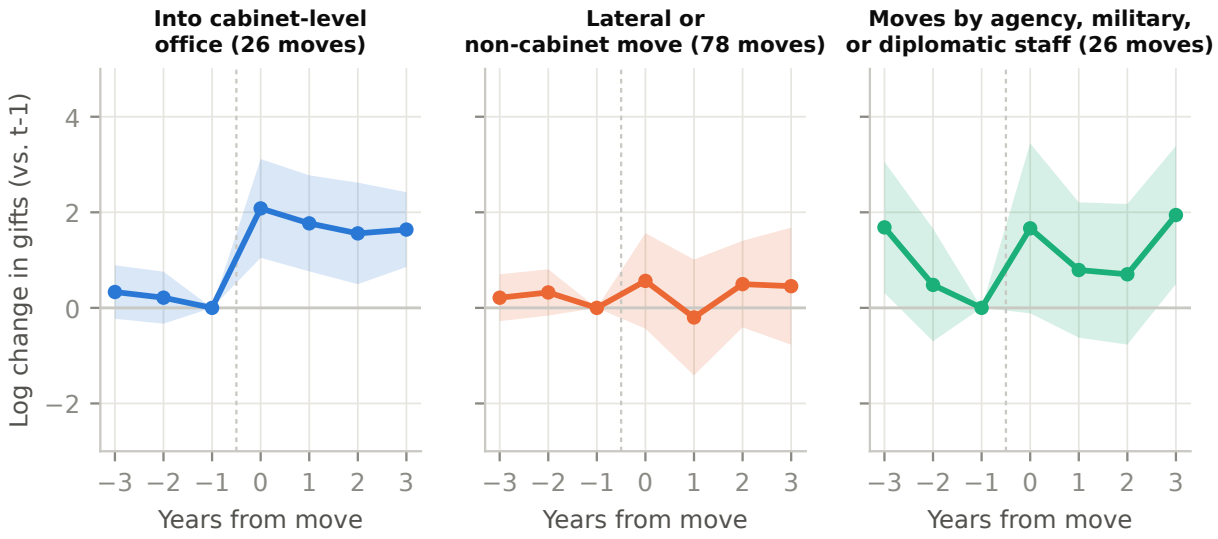


Figure 5. Gifts before and after a change of organization, by type of move (event-time coefficients with 95% confidence intervals; reference year −1). Specification as in Table 8.

dropped (Appendix A).

7.3 ORGANIZATIONAL CONTINUITY AFTER TURNOVER

Hypothesis 2 concerns what happens to an agency's foreign tie when the people who carried it leave. Table 9 separates three kinds of recurrence (O):

- through the original carrier;
- through other personnel of the same agency;
- total recurrence, through anyone at the agency.

Total recurrence falls when all original carriers leave. When at least one carrier stays, 64% of ties recur within three years. When all carriers leave, 47% do: a difference of 11 percentage points with agency-year and country-year fixed effects (SE 2.2).

Table 9. Recurrence of agency-country ties after the original carriers leave (O). Unit: an agency-country tie observed in year t through linked recipients. Recurrence: the country gives to the agency again in $t+1$ to $t+3$. Panel A shows shares; Panel B shows linear probability models with agency-by-year and country-by-year fixed effects and log number of carriers, with standard errors clustered by agency. When all carriers leave, recurrence through the original carrier is zero by construction. The ties come from 27 agencies, 21 of which remain after singleton groups are dropped.

	Any personnel	Other personnel	Original carrier	Ties
A. Share of ties that recur within three years (%)				
Carriers: at least one stays	64.3	47.9	42.9	2,245
Carriers: all leave	47.4	47.4	0.0	846
B. Difference when all carriers leave (agency-year and country-year FE)				
All carriers leave (LPM)	-0.112***	0.019	-0.320***	
	(0.022)	(0.029)	(0.036)	
Ties / agencies (clusters)	2,166 / 21	2,166 / 21	2,166 / 21	

Table 10. Do foreign contacts follow the person? Episodes in which a linked recipient is observed under agency A and later under agency B. Row 1: the share of the mover's gifts at B that come from countries that gave to them at A, against the same share among B's other recipients in the same years. Row 2: the same for specific foreign individuals. Row 3: at A, the share of other recipients' gifts from the mover's countries in the three years after the move against the three years before. p-values from 5,000 sign-flip permutations.

Comparison	Episodes	First (%)	Second (%)	Difference (pts)	p
Countries: mover vs. others at new agency	68	13.9	9.4	+4.5	0.108
Foreign individuals: mover vs. others at new agency	55	3.6	2.5	+1.0	0.652
Countries: old agency after vs. before the move	69	9.4	12.6	-3.1	0.017

Recurrence through other personnel is essentially unchanged. The share recurring through other personnel is 47.9% when a carrier stays and 47.4% when all leave. The adjusted difference is 1.9 points (SE 2.9). The fall in total recurrence comes entirely from the departing carriers' own repeat contact. The agency's relationship with the country continues through other personnel at the same rate.

Movers show only modest, imprecise evidence of carrying ties to new agencies (Table 10):

- At their new agency, 13.9% of movers' gifts come from countries that gave to them before, against 9.4% for colleagues there. The difference is 4.5 points ($p = 0.11$; 68 episodes).
- For specific foreign individuals the difference is one point ($p = 0.65$).
- At the old agency, the mover's countries account for somewhat less of colleagues' gifts after the move: 9.4% against 12.6% before ($p = 0.02$).

Agency-year models point the same way with very little power. Across 205 agency-years in 15 agencies, the share of last year's recipients who are gone is unrelated to the share of last year's countries that give again (-0.02, SE 0.07). A change in the agency's most frequent recipient is not associated with retention at conventional levels (-0.04, SE 0.03).

We read these results as evidence of organizational continuity with a limited person-carried component. The design has clear limits:

- Departure is observed only through the gift record, so it partly reflects how active a person is.

Table 11. Top brokers by position (X). Recipients with at least three gifts and a plausible identifier link ($N = 311$), ranked by betweenness in the 1998–2023 graph of recipients, reporting agencies, and giving countries. "Position held in gift years" is the Wikidata position covering the years of the person's gifts (weighted by gifts), else the title in the gift record. "Rank" is the overall rank. Participation and number of communities ("Comm.") come from the recipient-country graph, with Louvain communities (seeded).

Recipient	Position held in gift years	Rank	Betw. ×1000	Countries	Agencies	Particip.	Comm.
A. Cabinet level and above							
Barack Obama	President of the United States	1	66.85	110	2	0.78	11
George W. Bush	President of the United States	2	59.64	115	1	0.68	10
Hillary Clinton	United States Secretary of State	3	59.60	93	3	0.83	10
Joe Biden	Vice President of the United States	4	42.71	80	3	0.87	10
Condoleezza Rice	United States Secretary of State	5	37.80	72	2	0.83	11
John Kerry	United States Secretary of State	6	33.61	62	2	0.86	10
B. Agency, military, and diplomatic staff							
Gary Roughead	Chief of Naval Operations	29	4.33	14	2	0.77	9
Jonathan W. Greenert	Chief of Naval Operations	32	3.72	18	1	0.84	9
Capricia Marshall	Chief of Protocol	38	3.34	12	1	0.81	7
Michael G. Vickers	Under Secretary of Defense for Intelligence ...	53	2.34	13	1	0.84	8
Vincent R. Stewart	Director of the Defense Intelligence Agency	56	2.10	7	2	0.76	5
David B. Shear	Assistant Secretary of Defense for Asian & P...	57	2.10	4	2	0.72	4
John Holdren	Assistant to the President for Science and T...	58	2.06	5	2	0.73	4
James Stavridis	Supreme Allied Commander Europe	59	2.06	6	2	0.72	4
C. Legislators							
Mitch McConnell	United States senator	22	7.04	18	1	0.85	10
John McCain	United States senator	36	3.41	15	1	0.58	7
Richard Lugar	United States senator	39	3.19	17	1	0.83	8
Bill Frist	United States senator	42	3.07	11	1	0.86	8
Lindsey Graham	United States senator	45	2.82	9	1	0.74	6
Russ Feingold	United States senator	46	2.63	7	2	0.69	4

- Agencies with more ties may differ in ways the fixed effects do not absorb.
- Only 21 agencies contribute to the tie-level estimates, and 15 to the agency-year estimates.

The results show that ties recur through successors. They do not show that organizational routines cause the recurrence.

7.4 POSITIONAL BROKERAGE

Table 11 identifies brokers by betweenness and reports their degree (countries and agencies), participation coefficient, and the number of communities they reach (X).

Most top brokers are cabinet-level or above. Of the top decile of brokers (31 of 311 people), 29 held a cabinet-level office or above: presidents, vice presidents, and secretaries of state and defense. Every one of the top 20 is in this group. Cabinet officials also span communities most evenly (median participation 0.72, against 0.63 for legislators and 0.44 for staff).

Below cabinet level, brokers hold boundary-spanning offices. Among staff they are:

- military chiefs (the Chiefs of Naval Operations Roughead and Greenert, and Supreme Allied Commander Europe Stavridis);
- a protocol officer (Chief of Protocol Capricia Marshall);
- defense officials (the Under Secretary of Defense for Intelligence, the Director of the Defense Intelligence Agency, and an Assistant Secretary of Defense for Asian and Pacific Affairs).

Table 12. Career mobility and brokerage, with and without degree (person-year). OLS; standard errors clustered by person. Outcomes: betweenness (×100) and participation coefficient in the year-t recipient-country network. Sample: person-years with at least one gift from a known country and a dated career. Mobility measures use spells and gifts before t.

	(1) Betw.	(2) Betw.	(3) Particip.	(4) Particip.	(5) Particip.
Prior cross-sector moves	1.214***	0.141	0.040***	-0.003	-0.015
	(0.353)	(0.318)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.021)
Prior organizations	0.137	0.102	-0.001	-0.002	-0.003
	(0.210)	(0.143)	(0.007)	(0.004)	(0.015)
Observed under >1 agency before t	5.808***	0.832	0.202***	0.005	-0.017
	(1.633)	(1.207)	(0.030)	(0.023)	(0.030)
log countries at t (degree)		5.688***		0.225***	0.268***
		(0.804)		(0.013)	(0.015)
Evidence type	B	B	B	B	W
Fixed effects	year, sector	year, sector	year, sector	year, sector	person, year
People	562	562	562	562	251
Person-years	1,210	1,210	1,210	1,210	899

Among legislators they are senior senators on foreign-relations and armed-services committees (McConnell, McCain, Lugar, Frist, Graham). Each appears under only one or two reporting agencies. They connect many governments from a single office, not by moving between agencies.

Mobility is generally unrelated to brokerage once degree is controlled. Without a degree control, people with more prior cross-sector moves, or who have served under more than one agency, have markedly higher betweenness and participation (Table 12, columns 1 and 3, B). Once the number of countries a person deals with is held fixed, those associations fall to near zero (columns 2 and 4). They are also absent within persons (column 5, W).

Degree-preserving permutation tests show that the apparent mobility–brokerage association mostly reflects network size. Figure 6 compares each administration's observed correlation between betweenness and prior mobility with graphs rewired to preserve every node's degree. In six of seven administrations the observed correlation lies within the null range. The exception is Obama's first term: observed 0.12 against a null mean of 0.08 ($p < 0.005$). Permuting mobility across people, holding the network fixed, gives the same answer ($p = 0.40$). Mobile and prominent officials look like brokers mainly because they have more ties.

7.5 NETWORK CHANGE OVER TIME

The network changes over time (Table 13, Figure 7; N):

- *Carryover.* Between 55% and 61% of one administration's agency-country ties carry over to the next through Obama's second term. Carryover falls to 31% under Trump and 40% under Biden.
- *Segmentation.* Modularity rises from 0.25–0.32 in the Bush and Obama years to 0.39–0.42 under Trump and Biden, so the network becomes more segmented.
- *Concentration.* The ten most frequent recipients' share of linked recipients' gifts falls from 77% under Clinton to about 53% in Obama's second term, then rises to 69% under Biden.

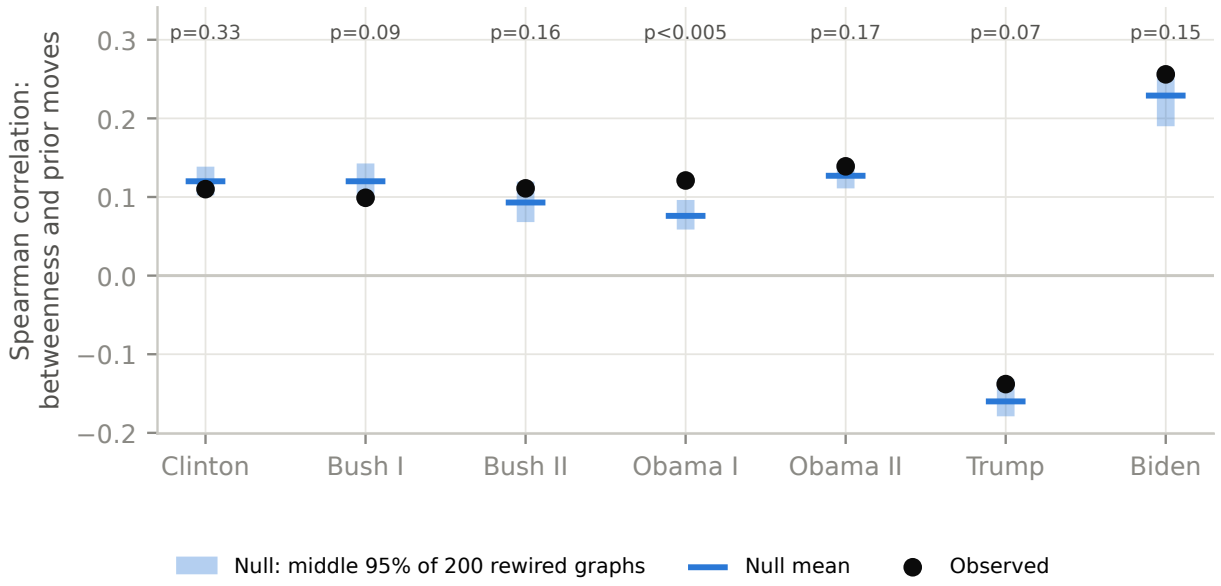


Figure 6. Observed versus null brokerage. For each administration, the Spearman correlation between a recipient's betweenness and their prior cross-sector moves (black dots), against 200 degree-preserving rewirings of the recipient-country graph. Every rewiring keeps each recipient's and each country's number of ties. Bars show the middle 95% of the null distribution; p is two-sided.

- *COVID.* The sharpest single break comes in 2020: recipient-country ties fall from 115 to 38, and only 9% of 2019's agency-country ties recur in 2020.

These shifts coincide with the post-2016 decline in reported gifts (Section 6). Changes in reporting cannot be separated from changes in behavior. None of the institutional reforms in the period (the creation of DHS in 2003 and of ODNI in 2005) produces a visible discontinuity at this resolution.

7.6 WHAT THE EVIDENCE SUPPORTS

The three claims rest on evidence of different strength (Appendix B):

1. **Position versus career: strongest support.** The pattern appears between people (B) and within people (W): cabinet office goes with far more interaction in both, entry into it is followed by a sharp rise, and career length and mobility are not positively associated with interaction. Interaction follows the office. The estimates do not identify why: visibility, protocol obligations, and authority are bundled in the office.

2. **Organizational continuity: descriptive support, limited power.** When carriers leave, agency-country ties recur through other personnel at the same rate, and movers carry only a modest, imprecise share of their contacts (O). The tests rest on 21 agencies. Departure is measured from the gift record itself.

3. **Positional brokerage: descriptive support, reinforced by null comparisons.** Brokerage is concentrated in cabinet offices and in boundary-spanning offices below them (X). The apparent link between mobility and brokerage disappears when degree is controlled and

Table 13. The agency-country interaction network by administration (N). "Kept from prev." is the share of the previous administration's agency-country ties observed again. Modularity uses Louvain communities on the agency-country graph. "Top-10 share" is the share of linked recipients' gifts that go to the ten most frequent recipients.

Administration	Years	Gifts/yr	Agency-country ties	Kept from prev. (%)	Modularity	Top-10 share (%)
Clinton	1998-2000	254	210		0.39	77
Bush I	2001-2004	495	393	61	0.25	74
Bush II	2005-2008	481	401	58	0.27	67
Obama I	2009-2012	582	498	55	0.32	54
Obama II	2013-2016	470	498	55	0.30	53
Trump	2017-2020	215	245	31	0.39	56
Biden	2021-2023	216	213	40	0.42	69

Table 14. Share of Wikidata-linked recipients and givers for whom Wikidata supplies each attribute (from a snapshot of statements for all linked QIDs).

Attribute (property)	Recipients (N=1,026)	Givers (N=2,361)
Gender (P21)	98%	84%
Date of birth (P569)	85%	80%
Citizenship (P27)	82%	80%
Occupation (P106)	91%	81%
Position held (P39)	59%	71%
Educated at (P69)	88%	65%
Party membership (P102)	46%	52%
Employer (P108)	31%	15%
Military rank (P410)	21%	15%
Spouse (P26)	14%	30%
Child (P40)	7%	19%
Father (P22)	11%	19%

against degree-preserving null graphs.

Two questions the theory raises are beyond these data. The revolving door into the private sector cannot be tested: the gift record ends when public office ends, and Wikidata records few private-sector spells. Career effects on behavior after appointment cannot be tested either, because the data contain no measures of behavior or decisions.

8 THE WIKIDATA IDENTIFIER AS A LINKING KEY

A QID is a join key and a gateway at once. As a gateway, it connects each gift to whatever Wikidata knows about the people involved. Table 14 shows that, for linked recipients, Wikidata supplies gender for 98%, occupation for 91%, education for 88%, date of birth for 85%, and at least one dated position for 59%. Coverage of givers is similar. Collecting these covariates by hand for 3,400 people in some 170 countries would be a project in itself. Through the QID they arrive with one batched API call per 50 people.

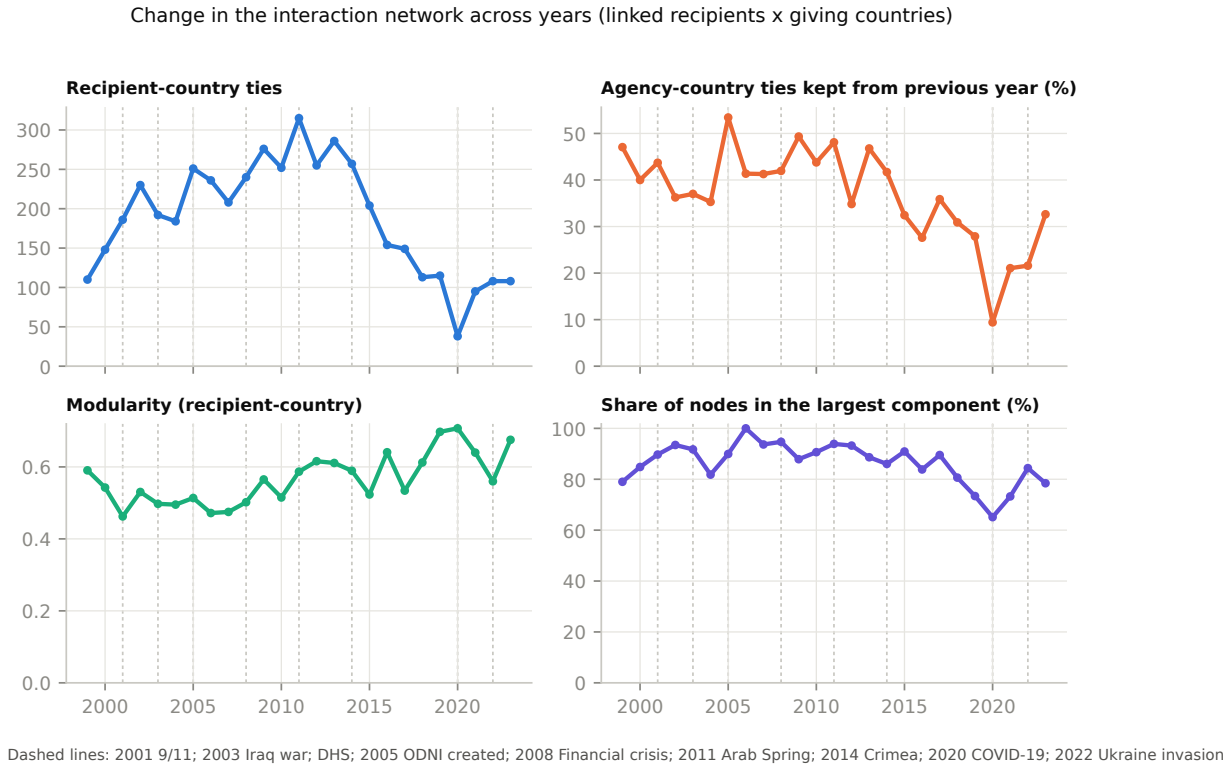


Figure 7. Change in the recipient-country network across years (N), 1999–2023. Dashed lines mark major events.

8.1 JOINING TO THE COMPARATIVE LEGISLATORS DATABASE

The Comparative Legislators Database (Göbel and Munzert, 2022) assembles individual-level data on more than 67,000 legislators in 16 countries and keys every legislator to both a Wikipedia page ID and a Wikidata ID. Because the CLD and our data share that key, linking them is an exact join. Table 15 shows the scale of the overlap. Two hundred forty-seven of our recipients served in the U.S. House or Senate at some point, and they account for 2,314 gifts, including gifts received *after* leaving Congress, as Secretaries of State, Vice Presidents, or CIA directors. On the giver side, 179 foreign officials sat in a CLD chamber, led by members of the Italian Chamber of Deputies (22 people, 164 gifts), the Japanese House of Representatives (31 people, 92 gifts), and the French National Assembly. Once joined, a researcher has, for each legislator-recipient, the CLD's political histories, committee and office records, and Wikipedia traffic, alongside the gifts that person received. With the CLD's R interface (Göbel and Munzert), the join takes a few lines:

Listing 1. Joining gift recipients to the CLD (R).

```
library(legislatoR); library(dplyr)
gifts  <- read.csv("analysis/output/gifts_analysis.csv")
house  <- get_core(legislature = "usa_house")      # one row per legislator
senate <- get_core(legislature = "usa_senate")
congress <- bind_rows(house, senate) |> distinct(wikidataid, .keep_all = TRUE)
```

Table 15. Recipients and givers who ever held a seat in a chamber covered by the Comparative Legislators Database, identified from Wikidata positions held (P39). These people can be joined to the CLD on `wikidataid` with no name matching.

Legislature	Recipients	Gifts received	Givers	Gifts given
Italy	0	0	22	164
Japan	0	0	31	92
France	0	0	16	79
Turkey	0	0	16	72
Canada	0	0	15	55
Ireland	0	0	7	52
Germany	0	0	13	46
Israel	0	0	14	46
United Kingdom	0	0	12	32
Czech Republic	0	0	11	24
Spain	0	0	9	15
Austria	0	0	8	11
Netherlands	0	0	5	10
United States	247	2,314	0	0

```
linked <- gifts |>
  inner_join(congress, by = c("recip_wiki" = "wikidataid"))   # exact key, no fuzzy match
```

The same logic extends beyond the CLD. Any dataset that carries QIDs, or that can be crosswalked to them once, becomes joinable. For leaders, the giving side of the gift relationship could be matched to leader-level resources such as Archigos (Goemans et al., 2009) and LEAD (Ellis et al., 2015): the match is done once, at the level of a few hundred heads of state, and the QID then carries it to every gift. Donor and ideology data such as DIME (Bonica, 2014) could be crosswalked the same way for American recipients. For countries, the ISO codes stored on Wikidata country items connect the country-year panel to standard cross-national data through existing converters (Arel-Bundock et al., 2018).

8.2 WHY THE KEY MATTERS FOR LIVING DATA

Persistent identifiers also make the link durable. If our data and the CLD both update, the join still works, because neither project's internal row numbers or name spellings matter. By contrast, a crosswalk built between two static files on names breaks as soon as either file is revised. The QID moves the work of maintaining identity out of individual research projects and into a shared, openly edited resource. When a Wikidata editor merges two duplicate items for the same person, every project keyed to that person benefits.

8.3 WIKIDATA UPDATES WHAT THE GIFT RECORD CANNOT

The gift record observes a person only while they hold an office that receives foreign gifts. Wikidata observes the whole career and keeps observing it. Liz Cheney appears in our data in 2005 as a Principal Deputy Assistant Secretary of State and in 2008 as "Vice President's daughter." Her later service in the House of Representatives (2017–2023) is absent from the gift reports but is recorded in Wikidata, with start and end dates, and arrives automatically through her QID. Mike Pompeo

enters the gift record as CIA director, but Wikidata supplies the four House terms before it. For a living dataset this is the key property. Because enrichment is re-run at every release, a recipient who later becomes an ambassador, a legislator, a lobbyist, or a convicted official acquires that attribute without anyone revisiting the gift data. The query that refreshes positions for any set of people is short:

Listing 2. Positions held, with dates, for a set of recipients (SPARQL, Wikidata Query Service).

```
SELECT ?person ?personLabel ?positionLabel ?start ?end WHERE {
  VALUES ?person { wd:Q6294 wd:Q473239 wd:Q5362573 }   # Clinton, Pompeo, Liz Cheney
  ?person p:P39 ?st . ?st ps:P39 ?position .
  OPTIONAL { ?st pq:P580 ?start }  OPTIONAL { ?st pq:P582 ?end }
  SERVICE wikibase:label { bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "en". }
} ORDER BY ?person ?start
```

The same mechanism works on the giver side. Abdullah of Saudi Arabia appears in our data first as Crown Prince and First Deputy Prime Minister and later as King. Rather than re-coding each giver's title by hand, a researcher can read the giver's office at the date of the gift from Wikidata's dated P39 statements.

9 AUTOMATIC TRACKING OF DIPLOMATIC CONTACT

A gift requires a meeting, or at least the delivery of a personal token from one official to another. Gift records therefore proxy *personal diplomatic contact*, and because each gift carries a receipt date, the proxy is timed to the day. This complements existing measures of diplomatic ties, which typically record embassies (Kinne, 2014) or leader visits (Lebovic and Saunders, 2016; Malis and Smith, 2021; Goldsmith et al., 2021). Gift records reach further down the hierarchy than those measures do, to commanders, deputy secretaries, and congressional staff, and they record who met whom.

The pipeline produces this measure automatically. Each release writes a balanced country-year panel (169 countries $\times$ 25 years = 4,225 rows) with the number of gifts, total value, and number of distinct American recipients. Only 43% of country-years record any gift, so the indicator varies a great deal both across countries and within them over time. Because the panel is keyed by ISO code, it merges directly with standard country-year data. Because it is regenerated with each release, a new year of contact appears without additional coding.

Two features make gift-based tracking especially useful for studies of particular events or relationships.

- **Event alignment.** With receipt dates, gifts can be aligned with independently recorded events: presidential and secretarial trips and foreign leader visits recorded by the State Department's Office of the Historian (Office of the Historian, U.S. Department of State), summits, arms sales, or crises. The match rate between gifts and visits is itself a validation exercise. A visit without a gift, or a gift without a recorded visit, points to an encounter that one source missed.
- **Relevant years for a given actor.** For any person or country, the data identify the years

in which contact with American officials occurred, and with whom. A researcher interested in, for example, Qatari engagement with the U.S. military can find the relevant years and counterparts directly, rather than combing through news archives.

10 APPLICATIONS

The finished data project supports research across several subfields.

Diplomacy and alliance politics. Gift flows provide a person-level measure of the intensity and seniority of bilateral contact. Researchers can ask whether contact intensifies before arms sales, basing agreements, or votes in international organizations; whether it shifts with changes of government in Washington or abroad; and whether some states cultivate the military rather than civilian leaders (Figure 3).

Influence, emoluments, and accountability. Gifts are the most literal form of foreign influence over officials, and gift exchange has deep roots as a mechanism of obligation (Mauss, 1990). The data allow systematic study of who receives the most valuable gifts, whether value tracks policy salience, and how dispositions (retained for official display, transferred to the National Archives, purchased by the recipient) vary across agencies. Linked to lobbying and post-government employment data through QIDs, they connect foreign gift-giving to later career outcomes.

Legislative studies. Through the CLD and Wikidata positions, gifts to members of Congress can be connected to committee assignments, seniority, and electoral histories. Congressional travel gifts (41% of congressional gifts) provide a measure of foreign-funded delegation travel that can be compared with legislators' committee portfolios, in the spirit of research on informational lobbying (Hall and Deardorff, 2006). On the giver side, foreign legislators identified through the CLD give a view of parliamentary diplomacy.

Bureaucratic politics and careers. The office/officeholder design supports studies of political appointees versus career officials (Lewis, 2008), of how ambition shapes behavior (Teodoro, 2011), and of how foreign relationships accompany officials across posts. The recipient profiles (Table C2) let researchers ask whether foreign governments direct more, or more valuable, gifts to appointees than to career officials, to officers than to civilians, or to officials with foreign education. The dyadic comparisons (Table C3) can be modeled directly: with the branch-year baseline as a null, a researcher can estimate whether shared careers, cohorts, or schooling predict repeated gifts or gifts that follow an official from one post to the next. Because Wikidata keeps updating positions, the post-government careers of recipients accumulate automatically.

Gender and the politics of the spouse. First ladies are among the largest recipients by value (Michelle Obama's 154 gifts total $1.8 million), and the data distinguish gifts given to officials in their own right from gifts given to spouses and family. Combined with Wikidata's gender and family statements, the data speak to research on gendered roles in political life (Teele et al., 2018).

Networks. Each release writes a person-to-person edge list (4,195 giver–recipient pairs with counts, values, and first and last years) suitable for network analysis (Hafner-Burton et al., 2009; Ward et al., 2011). Centrality measures identify the American officials who serve as hubs of foreign contact and the foreign officials who reach across many U.S. institutions. Bipartite projections reveal which American offices share foreign counterparts.

A template for other registers. Many governments publish gift, hospitality, and interest registers for ministers and legislators, in formats as loose as the American one. The pipeline's architecture, in which lookups are stored as data, entities are keyed by QID, and every step is rebuilt from source, transfers directly. Wikidata-keyed registers from several countries would support the first comparative study of official gift-giving.

10.1 THE INTERACTIVE APPLICATION

We are building a Streamlit application on top of the pipeline outputs. It will have two primary views. A *network view* draws the person-level edge list, filterable by year, branch, giver type, and country, with nodes linked to their Wikidata pages. A *map view* renders the country-year panel as a world choropleth with a year slider (a prototype is generated as `analysis/output/map_gifts_by_country.html`). Because the application reads only pipeline outputs, it updates when the pipeline does: a new annual report reaches the application without any change to the application code.

11 LIMITATIONS AND VALIDATION

Several limitations bound what the data can show.

Reporting is not giving. The data record gifts that were *reported*, above a threshold that rose from year to year. Compliance varies across agencies and over time, and an Inspector General review found weak controls over the custody of reported gifts (GSA Office of Inspector General, 2024). Changes in volume, such as the post-2016 decline, may reflect reporting as much as behavior. Values are nominal and are the agencies' own estimates.

Withheld identities. Nine percent of all gifts, and 99% of intelligence gifts, withhold the giver. These records support analysis at the level of the institution, not the person.

Parsing and coding error. Free-text parsing is imperfect, and the giver-type and country codes are heuristic. We report agreement between the two country sources (99%) as one check. Researchers should consult the original `item_orig` text, retained in every release, for any record central to an argument.

Wikidata is edited by the public. Wikidata statements can be wrong, incomplete, or vandalized, and coverage is better for prominent people and for some countries than others. Two practices mitigate this. First, each release should snapshot the statements it uses, with a retrieval date, so results are reproducible even as Wikidata changes. Second, identity links rest on human verification,

not on automated matching. The living design also exposes errors that a static release would bury. In preparing this paper, consistency checks revealed that several hard-coded officeholder identifiers pointed to unrelated Wikidata items, and that duplicate keys in a lookup table were silently duplicating about 3% of gift rows. Both were fixed at the source, and every derived file was corrected by a single rebuild.

Report year versus receipt year. Backlogged filings mean the report year can lag the receipt year. We provide both and recommend the receipt year for analyses of timing.

SUMMARY POINTS

1. The annual U.S. foreign gift reports are an official, person-level record of contact between foreign governments and American officials. The current release covers 10,428 gifts from 169 countries, 1999–2023.
2. A living dataset is rebuilt from source by code at each release and stores human judgments as versioned lookup data. This removes the main costs of static data: difficult updates and lost cleaning decisions.
3. Resolving givers and recipients to Wikidata identifiers turns merging into an exact join. Two hundred forty-seven recipients and 179 givers can be joined to the Comparative Legislators Database with no name matching.
4. Wikidata statements reached through the QIDs profile the officials who receive gifts. Recipients differ sharply by branch in military service, diplomatic careers, gender, and party membership.
5. Givers and recipients resemble each other more than random pairings would, but most of the resemblance is institutional: each office draws a characteristic foreign counterpart. Person-level similarity in career and cohort is modest, and shared schooling at American universities and military colleges is rare but above chance in the executive agencies.
6. Classified by career, technocrats, business people, military officers, and spouses tend to exchange gifts with counterparts of the same background, but sorting by office is much sharper. Background shapes the form of gifts more than their value once branch and year are held fixed.
7. The identifier separates office from officeholder. Fifty-three officials appear under more than one branch, which allows within-person comparisons across offices.
8. Wikidata enrichment is re-run at every release, so career information that the gift record cannot contain, such as later offices, accumulates automatically.
9. Gift records provide an automatically updated, date-stamped proxy for personal diplomatic contact that reaches below the head-of-state level, and the pipeline writes it as a balanced country-year panel.

FUTURE ISSUES

1. How well do gift records track independently recorded diplomatic contact? Systematic validation against the Office of the Historian's travel and visit records is the next step.
2. Do shared characteristics between givers and recipients predict sustained relationships, such as repeated gifts or gifts that follow an official across posts? Do foreign alumni of American universities and military colleges direct gifts toward fellow alumni?
3. Can gift reporting itself be modeled, separating changes in giving from changes in compliance, especially across agencies and administrations?
4. What standards (snapshots, provenance fields, change logs) should political scientists adopt when their data depend on an externally edited knowledge base?
5. Can the pipeline be generalized to gift and interest registers in other countries, enabling comparative research on official gift-giving?
6. How should credit and citation work for a dataset that changes every year and whose identity layer is maintained by a community outside the discipline?

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

The authors are not aware of any affiliations, memberships, funding, or financial holdings that might be perceived as affecting the objectivity of this review.

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[To be added.]

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A VARIABLES AND SAMPLE CONSTRUCTION

All variables are built by `analysis_revised/02_build_data.py`. Every column of every dataset is documented in `analysis_revised/CODEBOOK.md`, which is generated from the data and fails if a column is undocumented. Table A1 traces the samples from the gift records to the estimation samples, and Table A2 defines the measures used in Section 7.

Table A1. Sample construction.

Step	N	Note
Gift records (all report years)	10,428	
with receipt year 1998–2023	10,381	47 backlogged earlier receipts dropped
recipient linked to a human Wikidata item	7,389	QIDs that are organizations or link errors excluded
Linked U.S. recipients	1,015	
with a usable (dated, classified) Wikidata career	590	23 implausible links excluded
Recipient-year panel, all rows	26,390	1,015 people × 26 years
risk set (dated U.S. public office or a gift that year)	6,395	
in a dated position that year	5,614	5,610 in Table 7 col. 1 after singletons
Agency-country ties observed through linked carriers	3,091	three later years observable
agencies	27	
Mover episodes (agency A, later agency B)	76	
Career spells (P39/P108) of linked people	12,038	10,235 dated; 852 unclassified

Identifier linkage. The person-level samples are smaller than the linkage counts in Section 6 for three reasons.

1. Some linked QIDs are not people. 378 linked giver QIDs (1,108 records) and 4 recipient QIDs are states, ministries, international organizations, or link errors (Wikimedia category pages, a flag design). Linkage to a human item is 71.0% of records for recipients and 65.7% for givers.
2. Two heavily observed people had no Wikidata claims: George W. Bush (888 records) and Laura Bush (445). Their QIDs are assigned by the bare-office rule, which the enrichment step did not cover. Their claims were added from a supplementary download.
3. Twenty-three links have dates that cannot match the gift record, for example a person who died before the gift. Their gift records are kept, but their career measures are not used.

Linkage is far from random. It ranges from 84% of White House records to 35% of intelligence records, and from 96% for gifts from heads of state to 22% for unclassified givers. Item-level audit lists are in `analysis_revised/data/audit_*.csv`.

Career spells. A spell is a Wikidata position held (P39) or employer (P108) with a start date. Its organization is the position's "organization directed" (P2389), else "part of" (P361), else the position item itself; employers are their own organization. Its sector comes from ordered keyword rules on the position label, the organization label, and the item's types. Generic labels without an organization ("member", "board member") are left unclassified and do not count as organizations or moves. A spell with no end date is closed at the start of the person's next spell in another organization, else at death, else in 2025.

Prominence groups. The groups are assigned in this order:

1. *Cabinet level and above*: ever held the presidency, vice presidency, a cabinet secretaryship, or an office of equivalent rank (White House chief of staff, national security advisor, CIA director, DNI, chairman of the Joint Chiefs, UN ambassador, OMB director, U.S. trade representative, EPA administrator), or was First or Second Lady. Identified from Wikidata or from the title in the gift record.
2. *Family of officials*: spouses and children of presidents and vice presidents in Wikidata, or people listed as a spouse or family member in most of their own records.
3. *Legislators*: ever in a legislature, or receiving gifts reported by Congress.
4. *Agency, military, and diplomatic staff*: everyone else.

Table A2. Measures used in Section 7. "Prior" measures use only spells and gifts dated before year t.

Measure	Definition
Interactions (gifts)	Gift records received by the person in receipt year t (count).
Countries	Distinct giving countries in t.
Risk set	Years in a dated U.S. public position (legislature, national executive, diplomatic, military, judiciary, or ceremonial office), plus any year with a gift.
Cabinet-level office	Holds a cabinet-level or higher U.S. office in t (Wikidata).
Career length	t minus the start year of the first dated, classified spell; 0 if the first spell starts later.
Tenure	t minus the start of the continuous run of spells in the current organization (gaps of up to one year merged). The current organization is that of the most recently started spell covering t.
Prior appearances	Gifts received before t.
Prior organizations	Distinct organizations of spells started by $t-1$.
Cross-sector moves	Changes of sector between consecutive prior spells. Alternatives: sequential spells only; changes of domain (public, private, academic, international); changes of organization.
Change of organization (event)	Starts a spell in t in an organization not held in $t-1$, having had an earlier spell.
Degree	Number of giving countries tied to the recipient in the network window.
Betweenness	Normalized betweenness centrality in the recipient-country graph (year t) or in the recipient-agency-country graph (1998–2023).
Participation	$1-\sum_s (k_{is}/k_i)^2$, where k_{is} is the number of the person's gifts from countries in community s (Louvain, seeded).
Brokerage (bridging)	Reaches two or more communities.
Carrier of a tie	A linked recipient through whom the agency-country tie is observed in t.
Carrier left	Never again receives gifts under that agency after t.
Tie recurrence	The country gives to the agency in $t+1$ to $t+3$: through anyone, through other personnel, or through an original carrier.
Turnover (agency-year)	Share of the agency's linked recipients in $t-1$ who receive nothing from it in t.
Country retention	Share of the agency's giving countries in $t-1$ that give again in t.

Estimators. Poisson pseudo-maximum likelihood and OLS with fixed effects are estimated by iteratively reweighted least squares with alternating-projection demeaning, following `ppmlhdfe` and `reghdfe`. Singleton groups, and groups whose outcome is always zero, are dropped. All randomness (community detection, rewiring, permutations, placebo assignments) uses seed 20261105.

Robustness. The tables in `analysis_revised/output/tables/` re-estimate the main within-person models on several samples:

- excluding cabinet officials, the top 25 or top 1% of recipients, or the White House branch;
- staff only, and staff without the ten most-observed staff;
- Wikidata tenure years only;
- four definitions of a career transition and three network windows.

The results vary across these checks as follows:

- *Tenure.* The within-person tenure association (-0.17) is not significant whenever cabinet officials, the top 25, or the top 1% of recipients are excluded. It holds without the White House branch.
- *Cross-sector moves.* Within person, prior cross-sector moves are unrelated to interactions in the main sample. They become negative and significant once cabinet officials are excluded (-0.75 for gifts, -0.68 for countries).
- *Transition definitions.* When prior organizations are left out of the model, cumulative transitions are positively associated with interactions within person under all four definitions (0.50–0.58; significant except domain changes for gifts), because they then pick up the same moves.
- *Prior organizations.* The within-person coefficient survives most exclusions. It is not significant for countries without the top 25 recipients. Among staff (0.57, $p < 0.05$) it loses significance once the ten most-observed staff are dropped (0.52).
- *Network windows.* The brokerage results are the same with network windows of three years, five years, and all prior years.

B CLAIM-TO-EVIDENCE MAP

Table B1. Claims, evidence, and evidentiary status. Evidence types: B between people; W within person; O within organization; N network change; X cross-sectional.

Claim	Evidence	Type	Where	Status
H1: Position dominates career	Cabinet office: ×4.3 gifts between people, ×9.0 within person	B, W	Table 7	Strongest support
	Entry into cabinet office followed by +1.79 log gifts; lateral moves +0.32 (n.s.); placebo mean −0.01	W	Table 8, Fig. 5	
	Career length unrelated (0.02); negative without cabinet (−0.35)	B	Table 7	
	Tenure −0.41 (B), −0.17 (W); near zero without cabinet	B, W	Table 7	Qualified: composition
	Prior appearances +0.61 (B), −0.22 (W)	B, W	Table 7	Within-person sign biased
H2: Organizations retain ties	All carriers leave: total recurrence −11 pts; through others +1.9 (n.s.)	O	Table 9	Descriptive; 21 agencies
	Movers' old countries at new agency +4.5 pts ($p = 0.11$)	O	Table 10	Limited person-carried component
	Agency turnover and country retention: −0.02 (n.s.)	O	Sec. 7.3	Low power; 15 agencies
H3: Brokerage is positional	29 of the top 31 brokers cabinet-level; below cabinet, military chiefs, protocol, defense officials, senior senators	X	Table 11	Descriptive
	Mobility predicts brokerage only without degree control	B, W	Table 12	Descriptive
	Observed vs. degree-preserving null: inside null in 6 of 7 administrations	X	Fig. 6	Reinforced by null
Network change	Tie carryover 55–61% to 31–40%; modularity up; 2020 break	N	Table 13, Fig. 7	Confounded by reporting
Not testable	Private-sector revolving door; behavior after appointment; causal effects of careers or turnover	—	Sec. 7.6	Data required

C ADDITIONAL DESCRIPTIVE ANALYSES

The sections that follow appeared in the main text of earlier drafts. They are kept unchanged here because Section 7 now carries the argument. They describe recipients' backgrounds, giver–recipient similarity against random-pairing baselines, the technical, business, and political backgrounds of givers and recipients, and careers traced across branches.

C.1 WHO RECEIVES FOREIGN GIFTS?

The QIDs turn the gift record into a roster of the officials whom foreign governments cultivate. Table C2 describes the 1,026 linked recipients using Wikidata statements (coverage is reported in Table 14). The branches draw on distinct populations. Seventy-four percent of Defense recipients have a military career, and only 12% are women. Seventy-one percent of Diplomatic recipients are recorded as diplomats, and 32% are women, the highest share outside the White House. Legislative recipients are older (median birth year 1951), and 42% are lawyers, as one would expect of members of Congress. The White House group is the youngest (median birth year 1961) and the most often female, because it includes first ladies, presidential children, and National Security Council staff.

Table C2. Wikidata-linked recipients by branch of the reporting agency. A person who received gifts under several branches is counted in each. "Female" is the share of people with a recorded gender. "Military" means a recorded military rank (P410) or military occupation (P106). "Diplomat" and "Law" are occupation groups. "Party member" means any recorded party membership (P102). "Studied abroad" is the share of people with at least one school of known country who attended a school outside the United States. Missing statements count as absent, so shares other than "Female" and "Studied abroad" are lower bounds.

Branch	People	Female	Born (median)	Military	Diplomat	Law	Party member	Studied abroad
White House	135	35%	1961	10%	31%	29%	65%	21%
Diplomatic	223	32%	1954	5%	71%	11%	30%	17%
Defense	252	12%	1956	74%	6%	4%	17%	7%
Legislative	278	17%	1951	13%	6%	42%	87%	9%
Intelligence	19	11%	1953	47%	11%	16%	47%	11%
Other executive	155	19%	1952	7%	3%	20%	41%	15%
Judicial	19	21%	1948	0%	0%	95%	11%	22%
All	1,026	21%	1954	25%	21%	22%	46%	12%

Two columns speak directly to the study of bureaucracy. Party membership, recorded for 87% of legislators, is recorded for only 30% of Diplomatic and 17% of Defense recipients. Absence of a party statement is not proof of a career appointment, but the gradient is consistent with the distinction between political appointees and career officials (Lewis, 2008). The share who studied outside the United States is also low and varies by branch: 17% at State and 7% in Defense. As a result, a foreign official who wants a counterpart with shared educational experience will usually find one only by having studied in the United States. We return to this point below.

These profiles describe the *linked* recipients, who are more prominent than the officials whose names could not be resolved. Assistant secretaries, deputy chiefs of mission, and colonels are less likely to have Wikidata items than secretaries and four-star officers, so the table is a portrait of the upper bureaucracy. Because the profile is rebuilt from the claims at each release, it will extend down the hierarchy as more officials are linked and as Wikidata adds items for them.

C.2 WHAT DO GIVERS AND RECIPIENTS SHARE?

Because both parties to a gift carry QIDs, every gift is also a *dyad* of two people whose characteristics can be compared. We compare each giver with the recipient on seven characteristics: gender, professional career, military service, birth cohort, the country and the specific institution where each was educated, and employer. Similarity alone is not evidence of anything, since the people who meet American officials are not a random draw from the world's elites. We therefore compare the observed rate of similarity with two random-pairing baselines (Table C3 and Figure C1). The first shuffles givers among all gifts reported in the same year, which preserves the overall mix of givers and recipients. The second shuffles givers only within the same branch *and* year, which also preserves the kind of foreign official each branch receives. The gap between the observed rate and the first baseline measures the total excess similarity. The gap between the observed rate and the second measures how much of it remains once the office is held fixed. That remainder is the part attributable to the sorting of *people*.

Table C3. Characteristics shared by the giver and the recipient of each gift, compared with random pairings. The unit is a gift whose giver and recipient both have QIDs. "Gifts" counts those for which the characteristic is recorded for both people. The two baselines shuffle givers among gifts reported in the same year, or in the same branch and year, and average 500 permutations. "Ratio" is observed over the branch-year baseline. p is the share of branch-year permutations at least as large as the observed value. "Professional career" groups occupations into military, diplomat, law, economics/business, academic, and civil servant ("politician" is excluded). Panel B drops gifts reported by the White House and Congress.

			Random pairing (%)			
Shared characteristic	Gifts	Observed (%)	Same year	Same branch-year	Ratio	p
A. All branches (6,195 gifts with both parties linked)						
Same gender	4,513	76.3	70.0	71.1	1.07	<0.01
Same professional career	2,459	51.6	36.8	48.7	1.06	<0.01
Both have military careers	4,521	13.6	9.2	13.0	1.05	<0.01
Same birth cohort (±5 years)	4,262	30.0	28.2	28.6	1.05	<0.01
Educated in the same country	3,599	22.6	22.4	22.7	1.00	0.56
Same educational institution	3,627	0.8	0.8	0.7	1.14	0.20
Same employer	559	1.8	1.0	1.4	1.28	0.12
B. Executive agencies only (2,486 gifts with both parties linked)						
Same gender	2,254	74.8	72.3	73.6	1.02	<0.01
Same professional career	1,307	62.3	41.1	57.4	1.08	<0.01
Both have military careers	2,261	23.7	16.9	23.1	1.03	0.02
Same birth cohort (±5 years)	2,056	35.1	31.4	32.9	1.07	<0.01
Educated in the same country	1,678	21.2	21.4	21.3	0.99	0.65
Same educational institution	1,695	0.9	0.7	0.6	1.65	<0.01
Same employer	191	1.6	0.5	0.5	3.07	0.06

Most similarity is institutional. Givers and recipients share a professional career in 51.6% of gifts, against 36.8% under random pairing within the year. But pairing at random within branch and year already yields 48.7%, so about four-fifths of the excess comes from the office. The same holds for military service: 13.6% of gifts pass between two people with military careers, against 9.2% at random and 13.0% within branch. In Figure C1, this appears as the wide gap between the diamonds and the circles for career and military service. This is the protocol matching of Section 6 (Figure 3) seen at the level of individuals. A foreign general gives to an American admiral because the admiral holds the office that receives foreign generals, not because of any personal affinity between the two.

Person-level similarity is real but modest. Even against the branch-year baseline, observed similarity in gender, career, military service, and birth cohort is higher, by ratios of 1.02 to 1.08, and in all but one case fewer than 1% of permutations match it. In the executive agencies (Panel B), the excess is clearest for professional careers (62.3% against 57.4%) and for birth cohort (35.1% against 32.9%). Within the same office and year, foreign officials are slightly more likely to give to an American of the same profession and generation. Gender is a partial exception. Across all branches, same-gender pairs exceed the branch-year baseline by about five points, but in the executive agencies the excess is only one point. Gender matching is concentrated in the White House: 162 of the 233 woman-to-woman gifts went to White House recipients, most of them to first ladies and many from the spouses of foreign leaders.



Figure C1. Giver–recipient similarity relative to random pairing (the ratios in Table C3). Diamonds compare the observed rate with random pairing within the same year; circles compare it with random pairing within the same branch and year. The distance between them is the part of the similarity explained by the office. Gray bars show the middle 95% of the 500 branch-year permutations, so a circle outside its bar is unlikely to arise by chance. For a shared employer in the executive agencies, the bar extends below the axis because many permutations produce no matches.

Shared schooling is rare but striking. Givers and recipients attended the same institution in fewer than 1% of gifts. That share is still 1.65 times the branch-year baseline in the executive agencies ($p = 0.01$). The cases are concentrated in elite American schools and in military education. Admiral Gary Roughead, Chief of Naval Operations, received four gifts in 2009–2011 from a Saudi naval officer, Prince Fahd bin Abdullah bin Mohammed Al Saud, who, like Roughead, attended the U.S. Naval Academy. Colin Powell (2001) and Joseph Ralston (1999) received gifts from foreign officers who had attended the Army Command and General Staff College: Bahrain's Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa and Georgia's David Tevzadze. Ambassador David Hale and King Abdullah II of Jordan are both graduates of Georgetown's School of Foreign Service. The giver side shows the size of this pool. Of the 1,526 linked givers whose schools are recorded, 288 (19%) studied at an American institution, and they account for 22% of gifts from givers with recorded schools. Twenty-seven attended an American service academy or staff or war college, among them Bahrain's Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa, Egypt's Abdel Fattah el-Sisi, Rwanda's Paul Kagame, and Indonesia's Susilo Bambang Yudhoyono. Such alumni are the people that research on educational exchange and professional military education expects to carry American ties into foreign governments (Atkinson, 2010; Ruby and Gibler, 2010; Gift and Krcmaric, 2017). The gift record shows some of them maintaining those ties with specific American counterparts.

Caveats. The unit is the gift, so a pair that exchanges many gifts weighs more than a pair that exchanges one. Gifts are not independent, so the permutation p-values are descriptive. All seven comparisons depend on what Wikidata records. Coverage of education and employment is thinner for givers from some regions, and missing statements bias every match rate downward. This is also where the living design matters: the rates in Table C3 are recomputed from the claims at each release, so they will sharpen as Wikidata's coverage of foreign officials grows. The design extends naturally to richer measures of similarity, such as overlapping assignments, common postings, or shared membership in international bodies, all of which can be read from dated Wikidata positions.

C.3 TECHNICAL, BUSINESS, AND POLITICAL BACKGROUNDS

The officials on both sides of a gift arrive in office by different routes. Some are career politicians. Others are technocrats, such as economists, central bankers, civil servants, and officials of international organizations, and others come from the private sector. The background of an officeholder shapes policy (Adolph, 2013; Alexiadou, 2016; Hallerberg and Wehner, 2020), and it may also shape whom an official deals with and how. This section classifies givers and recipients by background and by the office they held when the gift was exchanged, then asks whether technocrats, business people, and politicians exchange gifts with different counterparts and exchange different gifts.

Coding background and office. We classify each person by the kind of work that fills most of their recorded career. From the dated positions (P39) and employers (P108) in Wikidata, we count the calendar years each person spent in four kinds of work:

- *Political:* elected office, heads of state and government, cabinet posts, and royalty.
- *Technical:* central banks, finance ministries, international organizations, sub-cabinet and diplomatic posts, the judiciary, and employment by a government agency, university, or research institute.
- *Business:* employment by a firm, or posts such as chief executive.
- *Military:* commands and ranks.

Overlapping jobs are counted once, an undated job counts as four years, and a general or flag rank counts as a full military career. The primary background is the kind of work with the most years. Under this rule, a lawyer who spent most of a career in elected office is political (Barack Obama, Joe Biden, Mike Pompeo). A politician whose career was mainly in business is business (Donald Trump, Silvio Berlusconi, Rex Tillerson, Steven Mnuchin), and a central banker or international civil servant who entered politics is technical (Mario Draghi, Ban Ki-moon). Spouses and children of leaders form a separate category, because they receive and give gifts through family rather than career. People with no classifiable job fall back on occupation and education codes. Table C4 also reports three overlapping indicators, which flag any technical occupation, education, or position, any business occupation, and any political career.

The office is coded at the time of the gift. For recipients it follows the reporting agency: the White House and Congress are political offices, State and USAID diplomatic, Defense, the intelligence community, and Homeland Security security offices, and the remaining executive agencies and the

Table C4. Backgrounds of Wikidata-linked recipients and givers. The indicators overlap; the primary background is the kind of work that fills most of a person's recorded career (see text). "Unknown" means Wikidata records no classifiable job or occupation.

		Recipients (N=1,026)	Givers (N=2,361)
Indicators (overlap)	Any technical	41%	29%
	Any business	11%	7%
	Any political	50%	65%
Primary background	Political	30%	48%
	Technical	33%	11%
	Business	4%	2%
	Military	19%	13%
	Spouse/family	3%	6%
	Unknown	11%	19%

Table C5. Who gives to whom, by primary background. Gifts whose giver and recipient both have a known background. Each cell shows the percentage of the row's gifts going to each recipient background, with the ratio to the share expected if givers and recipients were matched independently in parentheses. Ratios above 1 mean more gifts than expected.

Giver ↓ / Recipient →	Political	Technical	Business	Military	Spouse/family	Gifts
Political	48 (1.1)	21 (1.0)	7 (1.0)	12 (0.8)	12 (0.9)	2,964
Technical	42 (1.0)	27 (1.2)	9 (1.3)	10 (0.7)	12 (0.9)	420
Business	44 (1.0)	31 (1.4)	12 (1.7)	7 (0.4)	7 (0.5)	138
Military	23 (0.5)	24 (1.1)	6 (0.8)	44 (2.7)	4 (0.3)	631
Spouse/family	16 (0.4)	7 (0.3)	7 (1.0)	1 (0.0)	69 (5.4)	167

Table C6. Who gives to whom, by office at the time of the gift. All gifts with a classifiable giver office. Cells as in Table C5.

Giver ↓ / Recipient →	Political	Technical	Diplomatic	Security	Gifts
Political	65 (1.2)	3 (0.4)	19 (1.1)	13 (0.6)	5,469
Technical	25 (0.5)	38 (5.8)	14 (0.8)	22 (1.0)	841
Business	23 (0.4)	31 (4.7)	40 (2.3)	6 (0.2)	35
Diplomatic	60 (1.1)	5 (0.8)	23 (1.3)	12 (0.5)	361
Security	7 (0.1)	1 (0.2)	5 (0.3)	87 (3.8)	954

courts technical. For givers it follows the title in the gift report. Finance ministers, central bankers, directors-general, commissioners, and officials of international organizations hold technical offices. Executives of firms hold business offices. Heads of state, ministers, and legislators hold political offices, and officers and diplomats hold security and diplomatic offices.

Who has which background. The recipient and giver populations differ (Table C4). A third of linked American recipients are technocrats by career, about the same share as politicians, and a fifth are military officers. Foreign givers are much more often politicians (48%), reflecting the heads of state, ministers, and legislators who dominate summit diplomacy, and only 11% are technocrats. Business careers are rare on both sides: 4% of recipients and 2% of givers.

Table C7. The nature and value of gifts by the background of the giver and of the recipient. Median value and the share over $5,000 exclude travel. Gift types are coded from the item description by keyword; the remaining 12% of gifts (pens, desk sets, and miscellany) are not shown.

Background	Gifts	Median ($)	>$5k	Jewelry	Watch	Art, decor	Textile	Weapon	Book	Food	Travel
Giver: Political	4,688	570	7%	13%	7%	49%	4%	8%	3%	2%	1%
Giver: Technical	588	500	4%	10%	5%	51%	5%	9%	3%	2%	3%
Giver: Business	222	728	10%	13%	8%	32%	19%	4%	1%	1%	4%
Giver: Military	825	525	2%	15%	4%	41%	5%	16%	3%	1%	4%
Giver: Spouse/family	387	495	3%	26%	0%	43%	12%	2%	6%	2%	0%
Recipient: Political	2,254	566	6%	7%	3%	52%	3%	9%	2%	3%	8%
Recipient: Technical	1,525	540	5%	14%	4%	43%	4%	10%	2%	1%	9%
Recipient: Business	348	635	5%	11%	1%	55%	3%	12%	1%	1%	3%
Recipient: Military	1,087	632	5%	14%	14%	38%	2%	17%	1%	1%	3%
Recipient: Spouse/family	640	605	8%	31%	0%	45%	10%	3%	1%	1%	2%

Table C8. Log estimated value of a gift regressed on giver and recipient backgrounds and giver office, with branch and year fixed effects. Gifts with both parties linked and a known background, excluding travel. The reference category is political for each set of indicators. Standard errors are clustered by giver. "Value ratio" is $\exp(\beta)$, the multiplicative difference in value relative to the reference.

Term	Coefficient	Std. error	Value ratio
Giver background: Technical	-0.05	(0.10)	0.95
Giver background: Business	0.18	(0.19)	1.20
Giver background: Military	-0.45	(0.20)	0.64
Giver background: Spouse/family	-0.10	(0.14)	0.91
Recipient background: Technical	-0.12	(0.10)	0.89
Recipient background: Business	0.11	(0.08)	1.11
Recipient background: Military	0.16	(0.10)	1.18
Recipient background: Spouse/family	-0.01	(0.11)	0.99
Giver office: Technical	0.01	(0.14)	1.01
Giver office: Diplomatic	-0.37	(0.10)	0.69
Giver office: Security	0.21	(0.16)	1.24
Giver office: Unknown	-0.27	(0.15)	0.77

Who exchanges gifts with whom. Gifts pass between like backgrounds more often than independent matching would predict (Table C5). The pattern is strongest for spouses and family, who give to their American counterparts at 5.4 times the expected rate, and for military officers (2.7). It is weaker but present for business (1.7) and technical (1.2) careers. Givers with business careers are also overrepresented among gifts to American technocrats (1.4) and underrepresented among gifts to military officers (0.4). Political givers spread their gifts across recipient types almost in proportion. Sorting by office is far sharper than sorting by background (Table C6). Foreign officials in technical offices direct 38% of their gifts to American technical agencies, 5.8 times the expected share, whereas political officeholders direct only 3% of theirs there. Security offices give 87% of their gifts to American security agencies. The few givers in business offices give mostly to technical agencies and to the State Department. As in Section C.2, the office does most of the sorting. Background adds a weaker, person-level layer on top of it.

The nature and value of gifts. What is given differs more by background than how much (Tables C7 and C8). Givers with business careers give the most valuable gifts at the median ($728)

Table C9. Recipients who received gifts under more than one branch, with the sequence of branches and the years in which gifts were received. Fifty-three recipients meet this criterion; the fifteen with the most gifts are shown.

Name	Wikidata	Gifts	Sequence of reporting branches (years received)
Barack Obama	Q76	482	Legislative (2005–2008) → White House (2009–2016)
Hillary Clinton	Q6294	298	White House (1998–2000) → Legislative (2002–2007) → Diplomatic (2009–2013)
Condoleezza Rice	Q47216	246	White House (2001–2004) → Diplomatic (2005–2008)
Joe Biden	Q6279	229	Legislative (2000–2009) → White House (2009–2023)
John Kerry	Q22316	165	Legislative (2001–2012) → Diplomatic (2013–2023)
Bill Clinton	Q1124	151	White House (1998–2000) → Diplomatic (2009–2010)
John Owen Brennan	Q984191	83	White House (2009–2012) → Intelligence (2013–2017)
David Petraeus	Q28591	49	Defense (2009–2010) → Intelligence (2011–2012)
Leon Panetta	Q244631	49	Intelligence (2009–2011) → Defense (2011–2012)
Mike Pompeo	Q473239	47	Intelligence (2017–2018) → Diplomatic (2018–2020)
Antony Blinken	Q7821917	38	Legislative (2002–2009) → White House (2012–2013) → Diplomatic (2015–2023)
Chuck Hagel	Q381670	36	Legislative (2000–2006) → Defense (2012–2015)
William Joseph Burns	Q1276563	36	Diplomatic (2004–2014) → Intelligence (2021–2023)
David S. Cohen	Q20067627	23	Other executive (2010–2012) → Intelligence (2015–2022)
Susan Rice	Q50612	16	Diplomatic (2011) → White House (2013–2015)

and most often give gifts worth more than $5,000 (10%), and they give textiles and clothing far more often than other givers (19%). Military givers favor weapons and ceremonial items such as swords, daggers, and medals (16%). Spouses and family give jewelry (26%) and receive it (31%). Watches go disproportionately to American military officers (14% of their gifts). Once the branch and year are held fixed, however, most differences in value are small and imprecise. Gifts from business givers are about 20% more valuable than gifts from political givers, but the estimate is not distinguishable from zero. Gifts from military givers are about a third less valuable, and gifts from foreign diplomats about 30% less valuable, than gifts from political officeholders. The recipient's background makes little difference to value once the branch is known. Foreign governments appear to scale the value of a gift to the office and the occasion, and to tailor its form to the person.

Caveats. Business careers are rare, so the business estimates rest on a few hundred gifts. The classification depends on Wikidata's dated positions and employers. These are fuller for prominent people and for Western countries, and a fifth of givers have no classifiable career. The office codes for givers rely on titles in the gift reports, and a quarter of giver offices cannot be classified. Gift types are coded by keyword. All of these codes are stored in the analysis script, and the classification is recomputed at each release, so it will improve as Wikidata records more of each official's career.

C.4 OFFICE VERSUS OFFICEHOLDER

The study of bureaucracy has long distinguished the office, with its authority, its agenda, and its foreign counterparts, from the person who occupies it, with their ambition, expertise, and networks (Gailmard and Patty, 2007; Lewis, 2008; Teodoro, 2011). Many administrative datasets record only the office. The gift reports record both, and the QID lets us separate them.

Table C9 and Figure C2 show what this looks like. Fifty-three recipients received gifts under

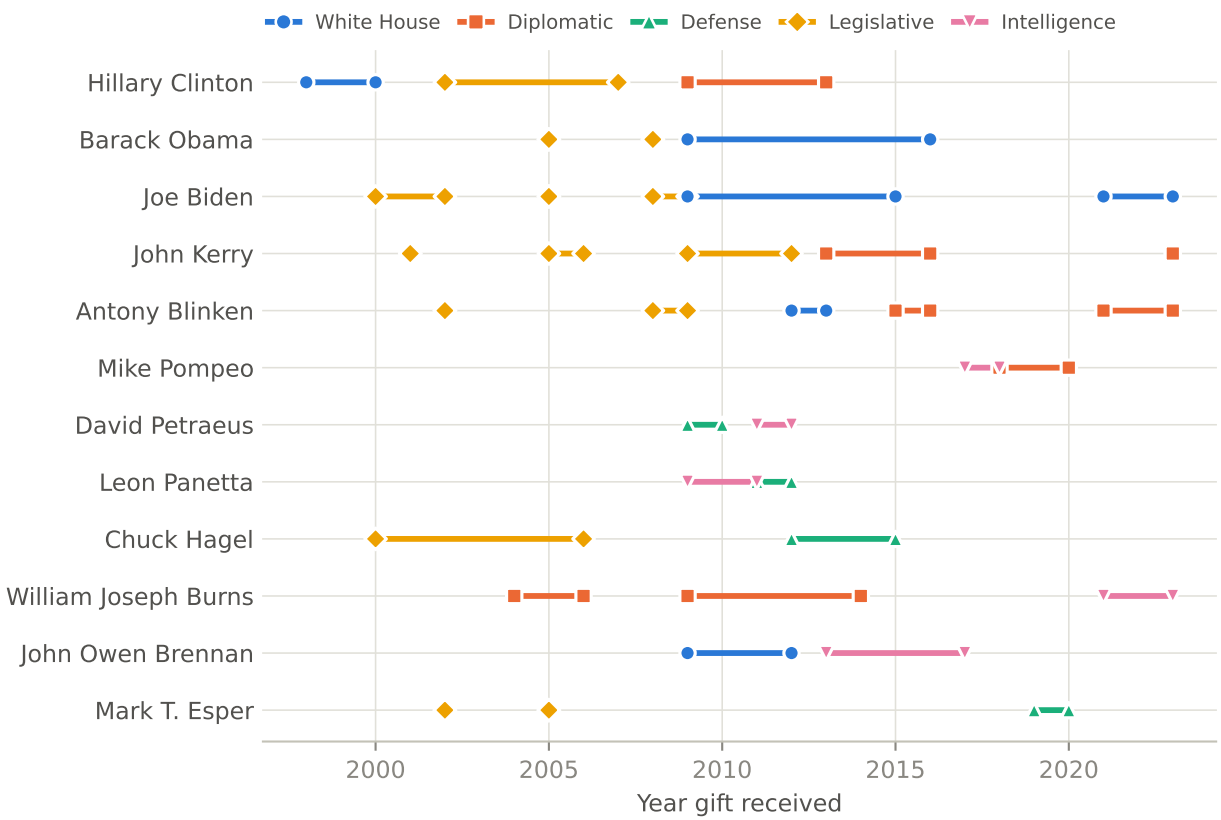


Figure C2. Careers traced through the gift record. Each row is one person (one Wikidata QID). Segments span consecutive years in which that person received gifts reported by a given branch; gaps of more than two years break a segment. Colors and marker shapes both identify the branch.

more than one branch. Hillary Clinton appears as First Lady (White House, 1998–2000), as a senator (2002–2007), and as Secretary of State (2009–2013). Mike Pompeo moves from the CIA to State; Leon Panetta from the CIA to Defense; David Petraeus from Central Command to the CIA; William Burns from the State Department to the CIA; John Brennan from the White House to the CIA. Antony Blinken appears as a Senate Foreign Relations Committee staffer, as a White House national security official, and as Deputy Secretary and then Secretary of State. The office-level record ("the intelligence community reported 947 gifts") and the person-level record ("Pompeo received 47 gifts, under two branches") answer different questions, and the QID lets a researcher move between them.

The design supports several kinds of analysis:

- **Within-person comparisons across offices.** Does the same individual receive more, or more valuable, gifts after moving to a more senior or more externally facing office? Holding the person fixed isolates the effect of the office.
- **Within-office comparisons across holders.** Do successive holders of the same post (Secretaries of State, CENTCOM commanders) attract similar gift portfolios, or do some holders carry their foreign relationships with them? A giver who presents gifts to the same

American across several of that person's posts is evidence of a *personal*, not institutional, tie.

- **Revolving doors and career paths.** Movements between Congress, the executive, and the intelligence community, and on to the private sector, are central to research on capture and influence (Dal Bó, 2006; Blanes i Vidal et al., 2012). The gift record observes the public-sector legs of these paths with exact dates.